



The Twisted Thicket

AN ADVENTURE FOR 4-6 CHARACTERS, LEVELS 5-7

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OSRIC / AD&D 2E Compatible — and the Second Fall begins

PLAYER'S MAP OF THE TWISTED THICKET



Distribute to players at session start. Shows roads, forest edge, and Ringstown only.

THE TWISTED THICKET

SF1 -- An OSRIC / AD&D 2E compatible wilderness adventure for 4-6 player characters of levels 5-7

ADVENTURE BACKGROUND

North of the settled roadlands, beyond the last safe timber camps and the sodden tracks leading toward White Plume Mountain, lies a tangled woodland known as the Twisted Thicket. In recent weeks, merchants, trappers, and patrols have gone missing there. Mangled bodies, shattered wagons, and strange white powder at the scenes have become the talk of nearby taverns.

The truth is more dangerous than rumor. Agents of a false inheritor of the ancient wizard Keraptis have been smuggling a refined magical stimulant called WHITE PLUME DUST through the thicket. The powder is a failed byproduct of attempted thought-transfer magic, fitfully carrying traces of alien intellect and violent impulse. Months before the adventure begins, an early shipment broke open in a ravine and an adult owlbear devoured the scattered cargo. The creature survived, but its flesh and mind were transformed. When a more recent wagon wreck drew the owlbear back to the ravine by scent, the creature re-exposed itself through contact with scattered traces of the dust still present at the site, deepening the addiction and intensifying the corruption that has driven it into bouts of ecstatic fury ever since. Those who sample the dust experience strength, obsession, and flashes of a hostile intelligence.

This scenario is designed as a compact outdoor adventure that can be completed in a single long session or used as a prelude to a deeper expedition toward White Plume Mountain.

ADVENTURE SYNOPSIS

The player characters are hired to enter the Twisted Thicket, discover the source of a series of brutal killings, and recover or destroy any contraband they find. Their search leads them through a wrecked smuggler wagon, a damaged logging camp, a corrupted glade, and finally into the thorn-choked hollow of the maddened owlbear. Along the way, they must decide whether to trust local wardens, bargain with smugglers, exploit the dust for power, or purge it at the source.

REFEREE'S NOTES

TONE AND STYLE

This adventure works best when run as a mixture of wilderness horror, dark comedy, and old-school resource play. The beast is terrifying, but the absurdity of a hyper-aggressive owlbear empowered by magical narcotic dust should still come through. Lean into signs of excess, trees clawed to splinters, half-eaten smugglers, glowing sneezes of white powder, and confused witnesses recounting impossible speed and human-like shrieks.

HOOKS

1. **WARDEN'S REQUEST:** A ranger-captain named Elnara asks the party to investigate recent killings and destroy any strange alchemical substance found in the forest.
2. **MERCENARY CONTRACT:** A patron in town hires the party to recover several casks of contraband before the authorities seize them.
3. **MISSING PERSONS:** A local notable offers a reward for the recovery of loggers and trappers missing in the Twisted Thicket.
4. **MOUNTAIN RUMORS:** Several survivors claim that the distant plume above White Plume Mountain now forms a face at dusk, and that the beast sometimes screams words in a human tongue.

SESSION INTRODUCTION: THE ROAD TO RINGSTOWN

This section presents a structured opening scene for tournament play, convention one-shots, or as a cold open for any group. It establishes the party's connection to Wave and to a second White Plume-linked mystery cargo without revealing Blackrazor or Whelm before Ringstown. Run this before handing out any maps.

THE CONTRACT

The player characters have been hired by BLINK TINDERFLIP, a gnome they met operating out of CRITWALL, to drive and ride two carriages carrying two sealed consignments of "sensitive cargo" along the road from Critwall to the frontier town of RINGSTOWN. The players are the coachmen and

outriders; there is no separate hired help. They are told only that the contents are fragile, valuable, and must be delivered intact to RANGER-CAPTAIN ELNARA at the Ringstown gatehouse. They are not told what is inside. The pay is generous. Blink is pleasant, evasive, and has already left town. The two consignments contain, unknown to the party:

CRATE	CONTENTS	COACH
1	Wave (trident)	Coach A, lead carriage
2	Sealed correspondence	Coach B, rear carriage

THE SEALED CORRESPONDENCE is a dispatch case, oilskin-wrapped and iron-clasped, containing field reports and contact addresses from Blink's network that Elnara requested under separate cover. It holds no artifact. Blink insisted it be treated as sensitive cargo to discourage the couriers from reading it, which is the kind of instruction that makes people want to read it. Its loss, if Coach B is destroyed, is professionally inconvenient but not catastrophic. The party should not learn its mundane contents until after they reach Ringstown, if they learn them at all.

Divide the players as evenly as possible between the two coaches before the scene begins. Each coach needs at least one player on the driver's bench; the rest ride inside or on the running boards.

READ-ALoud: THE APPROACH

Read this to all players before calling for dice.

Three days on the road from Critwall and the forest has closed in on both sides like a throat swallowing. The Twisted Thicket is what the drovers called it when they refused this contract, and now you understand why: the trees lean over the road, roots have buckled the old stones into a washboard, and the dark between the trunks is absolute. You have gone quiet. Those of you on the bench grip the reins a little tighter.

Ahead, perhaps half a mile, you can see the warm scatter of lights that must be Ringstown. The gate torches are burning. You are almost there.

Then something moves in the dark to the north. Not a sound exactly. A pressure. A disturbance in the tree line that the horses feel a full heartbeat before you do.

PERCEPTION CHECK

Each player rolls 1D20 AND ADDS THEIR WISDOM MODIFIER (2E: Wisdom magical defence adjustment, or a straight Wisdom check if the adjustment is not in use). Sum the totals within each coach separately.

The coach with the LOWER SUM failed to notice in time.

On a tie, Coach B (the rear carriage) is struck.

THE STRIKE

Read the following to the players in the lower-scoring coach. Players in the surviving coach hear this from a distance.

The horses scream. There is a sound like a mill wheel shattering and then the carriage is simply gone, replaced by splinters, spinning crate-wood, and a shape that does not stop moving. It is enormous. It glitters. Where its hide catches the gate-light ahead it throws off cold white sparks, and it moves with a speed that makes no sense for something that large. A smell hits you, bitter, sharp, faintly sweet, wrong in the way that lightning smells wrong. It is through the tree line and gone before you can draw a weapon.

EVERY PLAYER IN THE DESTROYED COACH MUST MAKE A DEXTERITY CHECK.

RESULT	DAMAGE
Failed check	2d6 trampling + 1d6 falling (3d6 total)
Successful check	1d6 falling only

The surviving coach and its cargo are undamaged. SCATTERED CARGO: Roll 1d6 for the sealed consignment from the destroyed coach.

D6	RESULT
1-4	Intact but thrown from the road; recoverable from the verge or nearby undergrowth
5-6	Outer casing smashed; inner case or crate remains closed unless forced open

If Coach B is struck, the correspondence case is lost on the road south of Ringstown, close enough that Elnara's wardens can recover it without the party's involvement. It is not a Thicket objective. If Coach A is struck, Wave is thrown clear and becomes the obvious recovery objective. In either case, do NOT identify additional White Plume relics here.

READ-ALoud: ELNARA AT THE GATE

The gates of Ringstown are already open. A woman in ranger's leathers stands at the threshold with a lantern held high, and her expression as she looks past you at the wreckage in the road is not surprise. It is recognition.

"That's the third carriage this tenday," she says. She looks at you, then at the surviving cargo. Her jaw tightens. "You'd better come inside. And tell me everything Blink told you." She puts a hand on one sealed container and closes her eyes for a moment, as if confirming it is still there. "Which I suspect was not much."

REFEREE NOTES

ON BLINK TINDERFLIP: Blink knows exactly what the two consignments contain. He is moving WAVE openly within his own network because it can be explained away as noble salvage under heavy seal. The second consignment is Elnara's field correspondence, mundane by comparison, but Blink treats it as sensitive because Elnara asked him to, and because he has learned not to ask Elnara follow-up questions. He withheld even this detail from the couriers to prevent loose talk. His shipping mark appears on dust caches elsewhere in the Thicket because the Inheritor's network has been routing contraband through legitimate carriers for months, copying marks and bribing intermediaries to make their shipments indistinguishable from ordinary trade goods. Blink is aware that some of his manifests do not account for all the cargo his network has moved, and he has chosen not to ask the questions that would produce uncomfortable answers. This is not innocence, but it is not knowledge either. ON WHAT ELNARA REVEALS AT RINGSTOWN: Elnara should confirm only that one crate holds WAVE and that the other contains correspondence. She should not mention BLACKRAZOR, WHELM, or the Revocation yet. Those names and that document enter play later through discovery in the Thicket.

ON THE MISSING CARGO: If *Wave* is lost in the wreck, it is the party's first concrete recovery objective. If the correspondence case is lost, it is close enough to the road that Elnara's wardens can retrieve it quickly, it is not a Thicket objective. The meaningful recovery objectives in the Thicket are the weapons and the Revocation, both of which were in Elnara's separate weapon convoy and are found at Area 2.

ON CONTINUITY WITH AREAS 1 AND 2: Whelm, Blackrazor, and the Revocation were not in Blink's coaches. They were in Elnara's weapon convoy, which crashed at Area 2 in a prior attack. The session intro establishes two known consignments: *Wave* and mundane correspondence. Everything else the party finds in the Thicket is a discovery, not a recovery.

ON THE OWLBEAR: The party gets no clean look at it. They know it was large, fast, and abnormally luminescent. This is their first encounter with the White Plume Owlbear and should feel like a force of nature, something that cannot be engaged, only survived. Save the full reveal for later areas. ON ELNARA: She will not share everything she knows at the gate. She confirms something is wrong in the Thicket, confirms that at least one shipment tied to White Plume has been hit, and offers the party a contract to go back out and recover what was lost. The deeper history of the mountain can wait until they have earned it.

THE NORTH GATE EVENT

Run this scene when either 20 minutes of real time have elapsed in Ringstown OR the party has visited three or more locations, whichever comes first. It ends the town phase, delivers the commission, and propels the party into the Thicket with no reasonable alternative.

SETUP

The event unfolds in three beats, each roughly a minute apart. The referee should not wait for a pause in player activity, interrupt freely. This is designed to cut through conversation.

BEAT ONE: THE GNOME AT THE GATE

A commotion at the north gate. Warden Drev's voice, pitched high:

"Someone get Elnara. Someone get Elnara now."

A gnome berry-gatherer, one of the mountain gnomes, unmistakable by size and the berry-stained fingers, has collapsed against the inside of the north gate. She is alive. Her left arm ends at the elbow, wrapped in a strip of her own coat. The wound is recent and cauterised, not cut, something burned it closed. She is holding a folded piece of bark in her remaining hand and will not let go of it.

If the party approaches before Elnara arrives, the gnome will fix whoever is nearest with absolute clarity and say:

"The hollow woke up three nights ago. Something is feeding it. You cannot wait."

Then she loses consciousness.

THE BARK MAP: Anyone who pries it from her hand finds a crude but accurate sketch of the Thicket's interior, the ravine, the logging camp, the glade, and a hollow marked with a filled circle and the word *do not go alone* in Gnomish. A character who can read Gnomish or succeeds on an Intelligence check recognises it as a gnome trail map, updated recently. It grants a +1 bonus to any navigation or tracking rolls made in the Thicket.

BEAT TWO: THE IMPACT

Before anyone has finished processing the gnome, the north gate *moves*.

Not opens. Moves. The entire gate, six inches of iron-banded oak, shudders inward on its frame, throwing dust from the hinges. A sound follows: not a crash, but a sustained impact, like something very large pressing rather than striking. Then silence.

Then it happens again.

The second impact is harder. A crack runs up the left gate post, hairline-thin but visible. The torches in the gatehouse go out. From the other side of the gate comes a sound that is not quite a roar, it is too rhythmic, too structured, and for just a moment it resolves into something that almost sounds like a repeated word.

The gate holds. The beast does not breach. After two impacts it stops, and the sounds of the Thicket, insects, wind, settling wood, return as though nothing happened.

The white powder sifts down from the gate frame like flour.

BEAT THREE: ELNARA'S COMMISSION

Elnara arrives at a run within thirty seconds of the second impact. She takes in the gnome, the cracked gate post, and the powder on the ground in one sweep, then turns to the party. She does not raise her voice.

"I have been waiting three weeks for someone capable of going in there. The town is not safe while that thing is active and the dust is still at its source. I need it stopped, the beast, the pool, the cache, whatever is feeding this."

"One hundred gold pieces, paid on your return with proof. Fifty more at minimum if you bring back anything that tells me who is behind the smuggling, and more depending on how much of the picture you find. I will have the gate open for you in five minutes."

She glances at the gnome. "And if she told you anything useful, now would be the time to share it."

If the party attempts to negotiate, haggle, or stall, Elnara adds, without inflection:

"The gate post cracked on the second hit. There will be a third."

REFEREE NOTES

IF THE PARTY STILL REFUSES TO GO: The owlbear hits the gate a third time within the hour. The post fails. The gate can be barred but not latched. Elnara will make clear, still without raising her voice, that the town cannot hold against a sustained assault, and that the only way to stop the assaults is to deal with the source. This is not a threat; it is a material fact.

ON THE GNOME'S TIMELINE: The gnome reports the hollow "woke up three nights ago." This corresponds to the owlbear's contamination spike and heightened pool activity. This heightened state lasts approximately 5-7 days from the adventure's start. A party that delays more than a week may find the frenzies less frequent and the pool's glow diminished, not resolved, but temporarily quieter. If a referee needs a mechanical guide: after 7 days, reduce the owlbear's Dust Frenzy uses to 2/day and the pool's ambient glow to barely visible. The gnome's warning is accurate about urgency, not about a hard deadline.

ON WHY ELNARA TRUSTS THE PARTY: She arrived during or just after the second impact. Everyone who stayed at the gate rather than retreating into the square is already ahead of most. She does not explain this or put it into words, it is simply what she saw when she turned around. There is no audition because the gate just administered one.

ON THE GNOME: She survives if given basic care. She will not accompany the party into the Thicket. She will confirm the bark map is accurate and add one detail: the hollow smells different at night than during the day. "Sweeter. Like it is breathing." She does not know why.

ON THE POWDER AT THE GATE: A character who examines the powder sifted from the gate frame and has previously encountered white plume dust will recognise it immediately, the beast left residue on impact. The gate itself has been dusted. This confirms the owlbear is the source of spread, not merely a victim of it.

ON THE BARK MAP: The map should be handed to the players as a physical prop if possible. It does not show Area 7 (the Riddle Cave), that location is not on gnome trail maps. Finding it is still an in-forest discovery.

TIMING NOTE: The entire event from Beat One to Elnara's commission should take no more than five minutes of table time. Keep descriptions short, keep Elnara's dialogue clipped,

and do not invite extended discussion between beats. The pace of the scene is the point.

WHITE PLUME DUST

White plume dust is a glittering, bitter-smelling powder packed in wax-sealed ceramic tubes or casks lined with bladder skin. It is dangerous but temptingly effective.

EFFECTS

A creature taking one dose as an action gains the following benefits for 10 rounds:

- +2 bonus to attack rolls
- +2 bonus to damage rolls
- +2 bonus to saving throws
- +2 bonus to morale checks, if applicable

BACKLASH

At the end of the duration, the user must save versus spells. On a failed save, roll on the table below.

D6	DUST BACKLASH
1	The user mutters "I am Keraptis" or similarly grandiose nonsense for 1d6 rounds.
2	The user becomes obsessed with locating more dust and must spend 1d4 rounds moving toward the nearest visible cache.
3	The user suffers vivid visual distortions and takes a -1 penalty to attack rolls for 1 turn.
4	The user scratches crab-like sigils or the letter K into nearby surfaces whenever idle for the remainder of the expedition.
5	The user loses 1 point of Wisdom until after a full night of rest.
6	The user hears a hostile inner voice and must save again or lash out at the nearest ally for 1 round.

MULTIPLE DOSES

A creature that takes a second dose before the first expires gains a second independent duration of 10 rounds beginning

immediately. At the end of each duration, the creature saves separately; each failed save produces its own backlash result, rolled independently on the table above. When two or more backlash results are active simultaneously, both apply, symptoms that conflict do not cancel, they stack. Taking three or more doses in rapid succession does not extend this further; each dose beyond the first adds one additional backlash save when the combined duration ends.

RINGTOWN: LOCATION DESCRIPTIONS

Ringtown is a walled frontier town of roughly 200 souls, the last settlement of any size before the Twisted Thicket and White Plume Mountain to the north. Its stone walls are old Shield Lands work, maintained out of habit and necessity. The residents are trappers, drovers, retired soldiers, and the merchants who supply them. Everyone here has heard the mountain. Most have decided not to think about it.

Locations are keyed to the generated hex map. Building positions vary by print run; names and inhabitants do not.

RING SQUARE

The cobbled central square serves as market, meeting ground, and the town's de facto court on fair days. A stone plinth at the centre once bore a statue; only the boots remain. Locals call it the Bootless King and leave small offerings there before dangerous journeys.

REFeree INFORMATION: The square is always populated during daylight. Rumours circulate freely here. Any roll on the rumour table (referee's discretion) made in the square gains a +1 bonus from the sheer density of gossip.

TOWN CRIER, ALDRIC'S BOY (use commoner stats): A gap-toothed youth named Fen who announces deaths, bounties, and weather omens. He has heard everything and understood roughly half of it.

ELNARA'S POST

The gatehouse beside the south gate is less a building than a fortified lean-to: arrow slits, a reinforced door, a rack of crossbows, and a cot that Elnara rarely uses. A hand-drawn map of the Thicket trails covers one wall, marked with red ink wherever travellers have gone missing.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Elnara's full statistics appear in the NPCs section. She is the party's primary quest-giver and the person holding the most accurate, if incomplete, picture of what is happening in the Thicket. The one crate that arrived intact from the session zero run, Wave, still sealed in its bladder-skin lining, is locked in an iron chest bolted to the floor in the back corner of the Post. Elnara will not discuss its contents, confirm its existence, or allow anyone near it. If the party recovered Whelm and Blackrazor from the Thicket and returns them to her, she accepts each weapon with the same flat expression and says nothing that constitutes an explanation.

GATE WARDENS (X2) AC 6; HD 1+1; HP 7 each; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS spear or light crossbow; MORALE 9 *Warden Pask* is a reliable veteran who trusts Elnara completely. *Warden Drev* is younger, nervous, and has been drinking since the third carriage came back in pieces.

THE PLUME'S REST

The inn smells of tallow, wet wool, and something fried in old fat. It is warm, it is loud enough to cover a private conversation, and the beds are actual beds rather than straw piles. Marta Holvik has run it for twenty-two years and has no patience for drama that damages furniture.

REFEREE INFORMATION: The common room is the best place in Ringstown to hear rumours and find other travellers. Roll twice on any rumour table when the party spends an evening here.

MARTA HOLVIK, INNKEEPER AC 9; HD 2; HP 11; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS ladle (as club) or sharp word STR 11, INT 13, WIS 14, DEX 10, CON 12, CHA 13 Marta has seen three separate groups head into the Thicket this season and watched two of them not come back. She will not be rude about it, but she will ask for payment in advance.

TOMAS HOLVIK, BARKEEP (Marta's nephew) AC 9; HD 1; HP 5; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS fist or bottle (as club) Tomas is cheerful, indiscreet, and has heard every conversation held at the bar for the past three years. He does not realise how much he knows.

PELL DAST, LOGGING CAMP FOREMAN AC 9; HD 1; HP 5; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS belt knife Pell arrived at the Plume's Rest four days ago, paid a week in advance, and has not left the common room except to sleep. He is not injured. He is very quiet and drinking steadily, which Marta permits because he is causing no trouble and he is paying. He has a ring of five keys on his belt, including the supply shed key from Area 3, which is

why the lock was picked rather than opened: whoever emptied the shed could not ask Pell for the key without revealing themselves.

Referee information: Pell was the actual foreman of the logging camp. He recognised immediately that Kael Vorst was not a real replacement foreman, Kael knew nothing about logging and moved wrong for the work. When the owlbear hit, Pell ran south. He did not witness Kael's murder, but during the chaos he saw a figure coming from the north treeline, moving fast and deliberately, while everyone else was fleeing south. He does not know this is relevant. He is not sure he saw it clearly. A character who spends an hour in patient conversation with him, and buys two or three rounds of drinks, can coax this out. He describes the figure as wearing something dark, moving wrong for a logger or hunter, heading north into the Thicket while the beast was still audible. He cannot describe a face.

THE SCALDED GOBLIN

Low ceiling, long benches, and a fire that someone clearly built too large and has been regretting ever since. The name comes from a mounted goblin skull above the bar, its jaw propped open in a permanent scream, which Grix claims he made that face when he tried the house ale. The ale is genuinely bad.

REFEREE INFORMATION: The Scalded Goblin attracts trappers, off-duty militia, and anyone who finds the Plume's Rest too expensive. Sorel Vane's surviving smugglers drink here when they are in town.

GRIX "SCALD" FENNOW, PROPRIETOR AC 7 (leather); FIGHTER 3; HP 19; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS fist or shortsword STR 15, INT 10, WIS 9, DEX 13, CON 14, CHA 11 A broad, scarred man with a mercenary past he does not discuss. Grix knows Sorel Vane by name and will say so if pressed, for a price. He is not loyal to the smugglers, he simply knows things cost money.

LIELLE, BARMAID AC 9; HD 1-1; HP 4; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS tray (as club) Lielle has memorised every face that has come through the door this season and will describe any of them in exchange for a coin or a compliment, whichever seems more sincere.

BREN FETCH, SURVIVING OUTFRIDER AC 9; HD 1-1; HP 4; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS knife One of Sorel Vane's six outriders from the Coach B run. He fled south after the wreck and has been at the Scalded Goblin for four days, spending down his emergency coin. He is not precisely guilty of anything the

party can easily name but he is frightened and lying about why he is in Ringstown.

Referee information: Bren can confirm the attack on Coach B, the owlbear, the speed of it, the dead left behind. He does not know what the cargo was (the outriders were not told specifics). He knows Sorel Vane's name and that Sorel had gone north to coordinate something. He does not know what happened to Mave or Dort. If the party reveals that Sorel is alive in the Thicket, Bren is visibly, quietly relieved and will tell them everything he knows. He knows nothing of real operational value but can confirm the coach's timing, the outrider count (six deployed, three dead at the wreck, one fled, two unaccounted for when he ran), and that someone else he does not recognise was already moving north through the Thicket in the same window.

THE BLACK FEATHER

Quieter than the Goblin, with actual candles on the tables and a board menu written in a careful hand. The proprietor, Widow Oaken, serves better food and worse company: she watches everything, volunteers nothing, and has a crossbow under the bar.

REFeree INFORMATION: The Black Feather is the preferred drinking establishment for anyone in Ringstown with something to hide. One of Blink Tinderflip's regular contact points when he passes through.

ALDETH OAKEN, PROPRIETOR AC 8 (DEX bonus); THIEF 4; HP 14; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS hand crossbow or dagger STR 9, INT 14, WIS 13, DEX 16, CON 11, CHA 12 Aldeth knows Blink Tinderflip, knows roughly what he trades in, and is not pleased that his last job has brought armed strangers and a frenzied owlbear to her town. She will share what she knows about Blink only if convinced the party genuinely intends to resolve the situation rather than profit from it.

THINGIZZARD'S SUNDRIES

A narrow shopfront packed floor-to-beam with dried herbs, sealed jars, coils of wire, bone components, inks, and a persistent smell of burnt hair. The proprietor claims the shop is licensed to use Thingizzard's name. Whether Thingizzard knows this is unclear. Whether she would care is more unclear still.

REFeree INFORMATION: Mundane alchemical supplies, spell components (common), and antitoxins are available here. Kelpwick has a small supply of items that counteract the

effects of white plume dust, he does not advertise this, but will mention it if the party describes dust-related symptoms.

DUST ANTITOXIN (3 DOSES AVAILABLE): A bitter grey tincture. A creature that drinks one dose gains a +2 bonus to its next saving throw against dust backlash effects. When administered directly to a creature already in active backlash or compulsion, applied rather than swallowed, it clears the ongoing symptoms over 1d4 turns instead. 8 gp per dose.

THE CLEARANCE BIN. Near the door, a battered wooden crate holds a collection of unlabelled vials, ceramic flasks, and wax-stoppered bottles, Kelpwick's miscellaneous inventory: things whose labels detached, batches whose notes he lost, experiments that did not go where intended, and stock acquired from other practitioners without full documentation. He sells them at 1 copper piece each. He does not identify them in advance. He does not offer refunds. He does maintain, with some dignity, that none of them will *definitely* kill anyone.

Roll 1d6 when a character drinks from a clearance bin potion:

D6	APPEARANCE / TASTE	EFFECT
1	Clear, faintly honey-sweet	POTION OF HEALING. Restores 1d6+1 hp. Kelpwick labelled this "uncertain efficacy" after a customer complained about the flavour; it works fine.
2	Murky orange, no notable taste	POTION OF INFRAVISION. Grants infravision 60 ft for 1 hour. The original label was in a language Kelpwick cannot read.
3	Thick, colourless, faintly oily	OIL OF SLIPPERINESS (MISLABELLED AS TONIC). Intended to be applied externally; when drunk, the drinker's grip becomes unreliable for 1 hour. All attack rolls and item manipulation (opening doors, using tools) suffer a -2 penalty. Applying it to a surface or object works normally.

4	Grey particulate suspended in water, slightly fizzy	PHILTRE OF SNEEZING. Save vs. poison or sneeze uncontrollably for 1d4 rounds: -2 to attack rolls, automatic failure on any attempt at silence or stealth. On a successful save, the drinker merely finds it repulsive.
5	Faintly iridescent, smells of bitter sweetness	FAILED DUST COUNTERAGENT. Save vs. poison. <i>Failure:</i> gain the white plume dust combat bonuses (+2 attack, damage, saves) for 1 round, then roll immediately on the dust backlash table. <i>Success:</i> no effect except that the drinker smells strongly of bitter sweetness for 2d4 hours, animals react to them as a dust-exposed creature, and the owlbear (if still active) detects them by scent at double normal range.
6	Dark red, no label, no smell, bottle slightly warm	UNKNOWN PROVENANCE. The referee rolls 1d6 secretly: on 1-3, this is a genuine potion of heroism (Fighter-type characters gain +2 effective levels for 10 rounds; others gain +2 to hit and +5 temporary hp); on 4-6, it is a slow-acting poison (2d6 damage after 1d4 rounds, save vs. poison for half). Kelpwick does not know which it is. He has not been able to bring himself to test it.

KELPWICK, PROPRIETOR AC 7; GNOME ILLUSIONIST 3; HP 9; MV 90 ft. ATTACKS staff or dagger STR 8, INT 15, WIS 11, DEX

13, CON 12, CHA 10 SPELLS (TYPICAL): *colour spray*, *detect illusion*, *change self* A small, fidgety gnome with ink-stained fingers who will not confirm or deny any specific relationship with Thingizzard. He has been in Ringstown for six months and has been quietly documenting reports of the white powder and its effects. He suspects the source is the mountain. He is correct.

HAMMER & THORN SMITHY

Anvil, bellows, and a dwarf who has been working iron for longer than most of the town has existed. The shop is Durven's entire personality. He is very good at it.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Weapon and armour repair, standard blades, and custom ironwork. Durven can sharpen, mend, and reforge. He cannot enchant and will become irritable if asked.

DURVEN ASH, BLACKSMITH AC 6 (natural toughness and leather apron); DWARF FIGHTER 4; HP 28; MV 90 ft. ATTACKS hammer (as warhammer) +1 to hit and damage (Str) STR 17, INT 10, WIS 12, DEX 9, CON 16, CHA 8 Durven has noticed that three separate caravans have brought wagons with the same type of bracket damage, the kind left by a very large claw. He has said nothing because no one asked. He will tell the party if they bring him work first.

PIP, APPRENTICE AC 9; HD 1-1; HP 33; MV 120 ft. A teenage boy with burns up both arms and an admirable lack of self-pity. Will run errands for the party for a copper piece each.

THE ANVIL RING

Bessa Kolm's smithy specialises in wagon ironwork, horseshoes, and the sort of heavy practical fittings that Durven considers beneath him. The rivalry between the two shops is entirely one-sided: Durven refuses to acknowledge Bessa exists, which Bessa finds very funny.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Bessa can repair a destroyed or damaged carriage frame in 1d4 days given materials. She can also identify the load ratings of crates and containers, and can tell the party that the crates Blink provided were built for something significantly heavier than they appear.

BESSA KOLM, SMITH AC 7; FIGHTER 2; HP 14; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS smith's hammer (as warhammer) STR 14, INT 12, WIS 13, DEX 11, CON 13, CHA 14 Practical, direct, and pleased to have customers who aren't asking her about Durven. She will

rebuild the party's destroyed carriage at cost if they bring her the salvageable frame pieces from the road.

WHITE PLUME ARMORY

The name is a joke, or was originally: Orryn Vault named it after the mountain because he thought it sounded impressive and nobody would ever take a Shield Lands soldier seriously enough to complain. The shop sells solid used equipment, nothing enchanted, nothing new, everything functional.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Standard arms and armour at book prices, with a 10% discount for anyone who mentions they are headed into the Thicket. Orryn considers this a dead man's discount and does not say so aloud.

ORRYN VAULT, PROPRIETOR AC 5 (chain shirt kept from service); FIGHTER 5; HP 30; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS longsword or shortbow STR 13, INT 11, WIS 14, DEX 12, CON 13, CHA 11 A retired Shield Lands sergeant with a long memory and a dislike of unanswered questions. Orryn knows the names of every expedition that has headed toward White Plume Mountain in the past decade and roughly what became of each of them. He will share this freely; he thinks people going there should know what they are walking into.

BRINDLE'S STABLE

Old Brindle, the hermit druid from the Thicket, once kept horses here before the forest pulled him away entirely. Yenna runs the stable now. She is not his niece by blood; the town has called her that for twenty years and neither of them has corrected it. She sends him money when she can find him and food when she cannot.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Horses, mules, and tack for purchase or hire. Feed and boarding available. Yenna can describe her uncle's habits and last known location in the Thicket, which overlaps significantly with Area 4 (the Dust Pool Glade).

YENNA BRINDLE, STABLEMASTER AC 8; HD 2; HP 10; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS pitchfork (as spear) or knife STR 12, INT 11, WIS 13, DEX 12, CON 11, CHA 13 Yenna is worried about her uncle. She has not seen him in three weeks, which is not unusual, but two weeks ago one of his marker-cords came back tied to a horse that had clearly run a long way. She will ask the party to look for him.

Referee information: Old Brindle has deliberately withheld from Yenna that the false Keraptis knows her name, he does

not want to alarm her. If the party mentions this, she will go very quiet and ask how they know. She will not panic, but she will not forget. Old Brindle has been protecting her; the party has just handed her information he chose to keep.

TOK, OSTLER AC 9; HD 1-1; HP 4; MV 120 ft. An elderly man of few words who is very good with horses and indifferent to people.

SHRINE OF ST. CUTHBERT

A modest stone building with a heavy door and a cudgel hung above the altar, St. Cuthbert's traditional symbol. The shrine doubles as a small infirmary when Ringstown needs one, which is increasingly often.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Curative services available: *cure light wounds* for 10 gp donation, *cure disease* for 50 gp. Brother Aldric will treat injured party members at no cost if they are visibly working to address the threat in the Thicket.

BROTHER ALDRIC, CURATE AC 8 (DEX); CLERIC 3; HP 15; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS mace STR 10, INT 12, WIS 15, DEX 13, CON 11, CHA 14 SPELLS (TYPICAL): *cure light wounds* x2, *detect evil* Young, earnest, and increasingly frightened by what he has been seeing in the infirmary: the dust backlash symptoms, the scrawled K-marks, the survivors who mutter in a voice that does not sound entirely their own. He will ask the party to describe anything strange they encounter and will take detailed notes.

THE SHIELD POST

The town's garrison: a squat two-storey building with a holding cell in the basement and a rack of polearms by the door. Warden-Captain Halven runs it with a small permanent staff and a rotation of part-time militia.

REFEREE INFORMATION: The Shield Post is technically the legal authority in Ringstown, but Halven defers to Elnara on anything involving the Thicket. He can provide the party with a signed writ of passage if needed, and can muster 1d6+2 militia in an emergency (use 0-level human warrior stats, morale 7).

COSS HALVEN, WARDEN-CAPTAIN AC 4 (chain and shield); FIGHTER 4; HP 24; MV 90 ft. ATTACKS longsword or heavy crossbow STR 13, INT 11, WIS 12, DEX 11, CON 13, CHA 12 Steady, loyal, and not particularly imaginative. Halven knows something is badly wrong and is relieved every time someone else agrees to do something about it. He will not obstruct the

party unless they commit an obvious crime.

THE TOWN WELL

An old stone well in a small open square, slightly off the main ring road. The surrounding stones are carved with worn Flan geometric patterns, suggesting the well is significantly older than the town. The water is clean and cold.

REFEREE INFORMATION: The well is Ringstown's primary gossip node. Any party member who spends 10 minutes here will hear one rumour of the referee's choice without any roll required. The Flan carvings, if examined by someone with relevant knowledge, suggest this site was considered a boundary marker between settled land and the old forest.

HEDDA, THE WELL-KEEPER AC 9; HD 1-1; HP 3; MV 120 ft. An ancient woman who charges a copper piece per bucket and has an opinion on every person in Ringstown. She has noticed that the water has tasted faintly of minerals for the past month and suspects it is connected to whatever is happening to the north. She is right, though the connection is indirect.

RING SQUARE MARKET

A semi-permanent collection of stalls occupying the eastern edge of Ring Square on most mornings. The market sells food, basic tools, rope, candles, dried goods, and whatever the current crop of trappers has brought in from the edge of the Thicket. Business has been poor lately: the trappers have stopped coming.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Standard adventuring supplies available at listed prices. The party can sell non-magical salvage here at 30-50% of book value. Fennick keeps records of what traders have been bringing in, or rather, what they have stopped bringing in.

FENNICK OYLE, MARKET MASTER AC 9; HD 1; HP 5; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS short sword (rarely drawn) STR 9, INT 13, WIS 11, DEX 11, CON 10, CHA 13 An officious, record-keeping man who is more useful than he appears. His trade ledgers document a sharp drop in trapper activity beginning six weeks ago, roughly coinciding with the first carriage disappearances. He will share this if asked about trade patterns.

MOSS & ROOT HERBALS

A shop that smells considerably better than Thingizzard's, filled with hanging bundles of dried plants, neat rows of small

clay pots, and a proprietor who actually knows what each of them does. Senna of the Long Road has been in Ringstown for two years and intends to stay until something more interesting arrives elsewhere.

REFEREE INFORMATION: Healing herbs, antitoxins (standard), and sleep-inducing preparations available. Senna can identify plant-based substances with a successful Wisdom check (roll under Wisdom on 1d20). She has seen contaminated plant matter brought in from the Thicket edge and has samples.

WHITE PLUME DUST (IDENTIFIED BY SENNA): She can confirm the dust is not natural, not purely alchemical, and not like anything in her references. She knows it affects Wisdom and willpower. She will provide this information freely because she wants it gone.

SENNA OF THE LONG ROAD, HERBALIST AC 8 (DEX); DRUID 2; HP 10; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS sickle or sling STR 9, INT 13, WIS 15, DEX 13, CON 12, CHA 14 SPELLS (TYPICAL): *entangle*, *faerie fire* Senna is the most practically knowledgeable person in Ringstown about what the dust does to living tissue. She has been treating early-stage exposure in townsfolk who found stray powder on the road. She is frightened and channelling it into competence.

CHANDLER'S WAREHOUSE

A large, draughty building at the edge of the town ring, used to store trade goods in transit. The Chandler family, now represented entirely by Brod, takes a percentage of everything stored here. Brod takes a percentage of that for himself. The arrangement has worked for twenty years and everyone involved pretends not to know how it functions.

REFEREE INFORMATION: The warehouse currently holds several unmarked crates that arrived four or five days ago and have not been collected. One of them has a very faint bitter smell around its seams. Brod does not want anyone looking at these crates. He is not connected to the smuggling operation but knows what a bribe looks like and has accepted one. The crates were dropped by one of Kael Vorst's intermediaries two days before Kael arrived at the logging camp; Brod can describe a lean man in travelling clothes who paid in Shield Lands coin, gave no name, and said someone would collect within the week. No one has.

BROD CHANDLER, WAREHOUSEKEEPER AC 9; HD 1; HP 5; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS heavy key ring (as club) or loud objection STR 10, INT 9, WIS 8, DEX 9, CON 11, CHA 10 Brod is lazy, mildly corrupt, and visibly anxious about the crates in bay four.

He will accept a 5 gp bribe to look the other way while the party examines them. He will accept a 2 gp bribe to describe who dropped them off. He will accept a 1 gp bribe just to stop talking about how he cannot possibly allow anyone into the warehouse.

KEY NPCs

ELNARA, RANGER-CAPTAIN

A practical warden of the roadwoods, Elnara wants the threat ended and the dust destroyed.

AC 4; CLASS Ranger 6; HP 34; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS longsword or longbow STR 14, INT 11, WIS 13, DEX 16, CON 14, CHA 12

On being named: If the party connects her to the cover name "E. Forger" (Blink's manifest) or the routing note signed E. (weapon-convoy manifest), she will not confirm or deny the name; she adds 10 gp to the commission without explanation and says nothing further.

SOREL VANE, SMUGGLER LIEUTENANT

Sorel ran the distribution leg of the dust network in the Thicket, dispatching crew to manage cargo movement without making the runs himself. He was not at the Coach B crash site. He knows the dust came from buyers connected to "a mind in the mountain."

AC 5; CLASS Fighter 4; HP 27; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS short sword, dagger, or light crossbow STR 12, INT 13, WIS 9, DEX 15, CON 11, CHA 14

VAREK SORN, DEEP OPERATIVE

Varek Sorn preceded the party through the Thicket, killing Kael Vorst (Area 3) and Orn (Area 6), carving fresh K-marks at the logging camp treeline (Area 3), and caching route intelligence in the Riddle Cave (Area 7). Unlike every other threat in this adventure, Varek Sorn has not left. They solved the puzzle at Area 7, opened the cache, and chose to stay. See the Area 7 encounter section for full details.

AC -2 (bracers of defense, Dexterity, ring of protection +1); CLASS Thief 12 / Mage 14; HP 55; MV 120 ft. THAC0 11 (+2 short sword); ATTACKS +2 short sword (paralytic poison, save vs. Death/Poison or paralyzed 1d4 turns) or dagger (thrown, 30

ft./60 ft./120 ft.) BACKSTAB x4 damage when attacking from concealment or surprise STR 12, INT 18, WIS 14, DEX 18, CON 13, CHA 15 SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 8, Wands 4, Paralyzation 8, Breath 10, Spells 7 THIEF SKILLS Move Silently 97%, Hide in Shadows 95%, Find/Remove Traps 90%, Open Locks 99%, Hear Noise 55% SPELLS PER DAY 1st: 5, 2nd: 5, 3rd: 5, 4th: 4, 5th: 4, 6th: 3, 7th: 2 PRE-CAST AT AREA 7: Stoneskin (1d4+8 hits absorbed), Mirror Image (8 images), Contingency (trigger: Teleport Without Error at 10 hp or fewer)

On allegiance: Not established. They possessed operational knowledge of Sorel Vane's crew by name, access to the weapon convoy routing, and the means to open the Riddle Cave independently. Whether they serve the false Keraptis, Elnara's network, or a third interest is deliberately ambiguous. The available evidence supports more than one interpretation, none of them complete.

On the name: In certain guild circles and counting-rooms the name Sarra of the Keys carries significant weight. The canonical reading is that Varek Sorn is Sarra: Laski's younger sister, the factor from Critwall, who lost the person she steered by to the thing in the dark water and has spent fifty years finishing what they would have done. The module text keeps this ambiguous to give referees flexibility. The adventure is designed to reward a referee who confirms it, in SF2 or later, when the party meets her underground and she finally says the name aloud.

On back-stab: Both confirmed kills in the Thicket were delivered from behind with a narrow blade. At Area 7, Varek Sorn is in a prepared position with their back to a wall they know and an entry passage that forces the party to enter one at a time. They did not take a fair fight in the Thicket and will not take one in the cave.

OLD BRINDLE, HERMIT DRUID

This ragged guardian watches the glade in Area 4 and believes the forest itself is becoming feverish from the powder.

AC 7; CLASS Druid 5; HP 24; MV 120 ft. ATTACKS staff or sling SUGGESTED SPELLS: *cure light wounds*, *entangle*, *faerie fire*, *hold animal* TYPICAL SPELLS (FULL LOAD): *locate plants or animals*, *entangle*, *faerie fire*, *hold animal*, *speak with animals*; currently reduced to *cure light wounds* (1) only.

GNOME BERRY-GATHERERS

Generations of mountain gnomes still emerge from hidden vents and root-choked paths to gather plumeberries in the thicket. Signs of their passage include tiny wicker baskets,

knotted trail cords, chalked directional arrows, and small boot prints mixed with berry stains. Their chalk marks are distinct from the carved K-marks left by the Inheritor's operation, gnome waymarks are rounded, gestural, and point toward destinations, while the carved K-marks are angular, deliberate, and point at nothing a person would want to go toward.

AC 6; HD 1-1; HP 3 each; MV 90 ft. ATTACKS hand axe, sling, or knife; MORALE 7

WANDERING ENCOUNTERS

Check for a wandering encounter once per hour of travel or exploration, or whenever the party makes significant noise. Roll 1d6: on a 1 or 2, an encounter occurs. Roll 1d20 on the table below to determine what.

If the owlbear has been defeated or calmed, replace results 5, 11, and 20 with result 1.

STATE-DEPENDENT RESULTS. Several results become invalid as the adventure progresses. When the conditions below are met, replace the indicated result with result 1 (Unnatural Silence):

- **RESULT 3,** Remove once the party has made direct contact with Sorel's group at Area 3. After that, the party knows Sorel's location and a chance road encounter is no longer plausible. This result remains valid if the party bypassed Area 3 entirely. Roll 1d4 rather than 2d4 for crew count; Sorel's numbers are reduced after the road attack.
- **RESULT 4,** Remove once the party has resolved the scavenger camp in the game trails (Area 6).
- **RESULT 12,** This scene and the body at Area 6 represent the same person (Orn, from Sorel's crew). Use this result only if the party has entered the game trails but not yet found his body; if it fires earlier, hold it. Remove it once Orn has been found.
- **RESULT 17,** Remove once the party has located Old Brindle at Area 4. Before that point, his appearance here reflects him returning to the glade after a brief absence; he should reach Area 4 shortly after the party does. Once his two-day vigil at the pool is established, this result no longer applies.

D20	ENCOUNTER
1	UNNATURAL SILENCE. No encounter, but the forest is wrong, no birdsong, no wind. The party's animals will not calm for an hour. Something passed through recently.

2	GIANT WEASELS (1D4). Driven from their burrows by trace dust exposure. Frothing, erratic, and faster than they should be. They pursue if the party retreats.
3	SOREL VANE'S CREW (2D4 SMUGGLERS). Searching the trail for the scattered crates from the wreck. Armed and nervous. Initially hostile; they can be negotiated with if the party demonstrates they want the dust destroyed rather than claimed.
4	RIVAL SCAVENGERS (2D4). A competing faction of opportunists from Critwall, armed with crossbows, who mistake the party for Sorel's crew. Hostile until corrected. If convinced the party is not Sorel's people, they will sell information about the smuggling network's structure for 10 gp.
5	DISTANT SHRIEK. The owlbear cries out somewhere to the north, not a territorial call but something that sounds briefly, horribly, like a name. All characters are surprised on a roll of 1-2 in the next encounter this session.
6	DEAD CART-HORSE. Still in harness, coat dusted white, eyes open. Very recently killed, not yet cold. There is no cart, no driver, and no trail leading away.
7	WHITE PLUME DUST (1D3 DOSES). A wax-sealed ceramic tube half-buried in the trail mud, stamped with a crude K. See the White Plume Dust section for effects.
8	GIANT RATS (1D4). Nesting in the ruins of a collapsed trapper's cache. The cache contains 2d6 days of rations, one dose of dust wrapped in oilcloth, and a coded note referencing a rendezvous at "the camp."
9	STIRGES (2D6). A roosting colony in a hollow oak, disturbed by movement. They attack immediately and pursue for up to three rounds before breaking off.

10	GNOME BERRY-GATHERERS (ID3). They vanish into the undergrowth if approached directly. They leave behind a knotted warning cord hung at chest height across the path. A successful Wisdom check or ranger tracking roll reads it as: <i>large beast, north, do not follow the light.</i>
11	THE OWLBEAR CROSSES THE PATH. Sixty feet ahead, moving at speed, trailing cold white sparks. It does not stop. It does not look at the party. It is gone in two rounds. No action is possible. The smell of bitter sweetness lingers for ten minutes.
12	A DEAD SMUGGLER, propped upright against a tree as though sleeping. The letter K has been carved into his forehead, recent, deliberate, post-mortem. A sealed crate rests between his knees containing 3 doses of dust and a folded note.
13	LOST GNOME. A single gnome berry-gatherer, separated from her group and clearly frightened. She will not speak of the mountain. She will trade directions to Area 7 (the Riddle Cave of the Ash Tongue) in exchange for escort to the forest edge. <i>This is Nib, who also appears as a fixed encounter in Area 6 (Game Trails). If the party encounters her here, she has the same knowledge and motivations described there. Remove this entry once Area 6 has been fully explored.</i>
14	CORRUPTED VEGETATION. The plants in a twenty-foot radius are bent toward an unseen centre, flowers open the wrong direction, bark split along lines that form partial letters. The ground underfoot is faintly warm. Any character who lingers more than one round must save vs. spells or feel an overwhelming urge to carve something into the nearest surface.

15	FRESH K-MARKS. A dozen trees in a loose circle around the party's current position have been freshly carved. They were not there when the party entered this area. No creature is visible. Listening carefully: something breathes.
16	DUST WOLVES (ID3). Wolves whose eyes are filmed white, moving in stuttering, arrhythmic patterns. They attack but their coordination is broken, all attack rolls made against them gain a +1 bonus. Morale is 7, reduced to 5 after the first of them takes damage.
17	OLD BRINDLE, moving fast through the undergrowth, muttering. He will pause to speak briefly: <i>"The pool is thirsty tonight. Something fed it."</i> He then disappears into the dark before questions can be asked. He is heading toward Area 4.
18	A SURVIVOR FROM THE LOGGING CAMP, mute from shock, huddled under a fallen trunk. He cannot speak but can draw, given paper and charcoal, he will produce a crude but accurate map of the logging camp layout (Area 3) and indicate with frantic hashing where the beast came from.
19	DUST TRAIL. A smeared path of glittering white powder and claw-prints leads north through the undergrowth. Following it requires no tracking rolls and leads directly to Area 5 (Thorn-Choked Hollow). The trail is fresh. The prints are still warm.
20	THE HOLLOW IS CLOSE. The party finds a spray of powdered bone across the path, a claw-mark gouged eight feet up a pine, and the thick, cold smell of bitter sweetness. They have reached the threshold of Area 5 without further navigation. Proceed directly to the Thorn-Choked Hollow entry.

AREA 1: FOREST EDGE ROAD

The road does not end, it simply stops being believed in. The stone flags give way to churned mud, the mud gives way to splinters, and the splinters give way to dark. Broken campfires and abandoned gear line the verge where drovers turned back and did not try again. The tree line begins without warning: one step you are on the road, the next the canopy closes overhead and the light goes grey. Something in the dark ahead makes a slow, wet sound of wood under pressure.

WHAT THE TRACKS SHOW

The mud at the forest edge is a record. A careful examination, a ranger's tracking check, a thief's observation roll, or simply ten minutes of methodical looking, reveals the following layers, oldest to most recent:

THE WRECK. Two sets of deep wheel ruts enter from the south and stop abruptly fifteen feet from the treeline. One set ends cleanly. The other splays outward into a fan of gouged earth and scattered debris, as though the coach was struck from the side and spun. Splinters of painted oak are still embedded in the mud. The paint is dark red, the colour of the coaches Blink Tinderflip commissioned.

THE BEAST. Three-toed prints, each the size of a buckler, press eight inches into the mud where the second coach came apart. The stride is enormous, six feet between prints, indicating speed rather than weight. The tracks enter from the north, cross the road in four strides, and return north. In the deepest impressions, a fine white powder has settled and dried to a faint crust. It glitters faintly in direct light.

THE DRAG. Overlapping the beast's departure tracks: two parallel grooves in the mud, each about eight inches wide, running north into the trees. The grooves are deep and evenly spaced, something was dragged, not rolled, and it was heavy. The drag marks stop at the treeline. Beyond, the forest floor is pine duff and root, and the trail is lost.

THE SCAVENGERS. Boot prints, several sets, all entering from the south and retreating south. None of them cross into the trees. The most recent set belongs to whoever came last and stood at the treeline for a long time before turning back.

PHYSICAL EVIDENCE

THE BROKEN CRATE. Twenty feet into the undergrowth, visible from the road if anyone looks carefully: a splintered

wooden crate, its lid staved in, its iron strapping bent outward. The crate is empty. Its interior lining, bladder skin, still faintly damp, has been peeled back. Whatever was inside is gone. The crate bears a stamped mark on the base: a stylised T inside a circle, Blink Tinderflip's shipping mark.

THE IMPACT STONE. At the edge of the road, a flat paving stone is cracked cleanly through with a circular depression at the centre, as though something extremely heavy fell point-first onto it from height. The depression is roughly the diameter of a warhammer head. The crack radiates outward in six lines. The stone is cold to the touch, noticeably colder than the surrounding road, and remains so regardless of weather. A ranger's tracking check or ten minutes of careful comparison confirms this damage predates the carriage wreck: the crack edges have settled, a thin skin of dried mud has formed inside the depression, and the splintered oak from Blink's coach lies on top of the older impact scar rather than beside it. Something struck here days before the coaches arrived.

THE LONG GOUGE. A shallow groove runs from the impact stone twelve feet north into the mud, then curves northeast into the treeline. The groove is consistent with a long, heavy blade being dragged or skidding across the ground. At the end of the groove, pressed into the mud, is a partial handprint, five fingers, too large for a man, consistent with an owlbear's forepad. Like the impact stone, this evidence predates the carriage wreck. Two separate events happened in the same place days apart, and the newer wreck nearly obscures the older one.

WHAT CAN BE FOUND HERE

WHELM is not here. The impact stone marks where it landed in the earlier attack; the weapon has sunk into the mud at the ravine's edge or rolled east in the days since. It will be found at Area 2.

BLACKRAZOR was carried north by the owlbear and dropped somewhere in the Thicket. Its trail, the gouge, the northeastern curve, points toward Area 6 (Game Trails). A character who succeeds on a Wisdom check while examining the gouge feels a faint pull of unease from the northeast, like the memory of a sound just below hearing. This sensation intensifies closer to the weapon.

THE DUST RESIDUE in the beast's prints can be collected, enough for half a dose if scraped carefully. Any character who touches it bare-handed must save vs. Death/Poison or experience a single round of mild euphoria (no mechanical effect, but the referee should describe it vividly enough to be tempting).

THE BARK MAP from the gnome at the north gate, if the party has it, shows a marked trail leading north from this exact point. The gnome who drew it knew this road.

REFEREE NOTES

ON THE RAVINE: Area 2 lies east of the main north trail, not on it. A party that moves straight north without examining the ravine will bypass Whelm, the Revocation, the coded ledger, and both manifests, the adventure's densest intelligence deposit. The ravine is not hidden: from the treeline the sound of the stream is audible and the ground drops visibly to the east. If the party attempts to move straight north without investigating, the referee should note the sound of water and the gouge that curves east. The decision to descend is theirs; missing Area 2 is a valid outcome, not a referee failure.

ON PACE: This area is a threshold, not a destination. The party should spend no more than one exploration turn here before the trail pulls them north. The tracks are readable quickly; reward the first person who looks rather than making the whole party roll.

ON THE COLD STONE: Any character who lingers near the impact stone for more than a round notices that their breath fogs slightly, even if the air is warm. Whelm's presence lingers in the ground it struck. A dwarf character feels this as a faint vibration rather than cold, a hammered note still ringing in the stone.

ON BLACKRAZOR'S TRAIL: The pull felt from the northeast is not magical compulsion, it is the weapon's latent presence bleeding into the environment. Characters with high Wisdom (13+) feel it without a roll. Characters who have previously handled Blackrazor feel it strongly enough to follow without any check at all.

ON THE PRIOR ATTACK: The impact stone and long gouge predate Blink's carriage wreck by approximately a week. A separate, unmarked convoy, no commercial livery, no Tinderflip mark, was attacked at this spot during its passage north. The convoy was carrying Whelm, Blackrazor, and the Revocation, moving them toward White Plume Mountain as deliberate bait: an attempt to draw the false Keraptis out of the mountain by placing what he most wants to recover within reach and then closing the trap. Elnara authorized and directed this operation, acting under the Shield Lands intelligence backing she does not advertise. It failed. The owlbear struck the convoy here, took Blackrazor north toward what would become its hollow, and left Whelm where it fell. Whelm rolled east toward the ravine in the days that followed. The convoy's operatives were killed; their bodies were removed by the silk-wearing operative before anyone else reached the scene.

Elnara has told no one in Ringstown what she set in motion. The cracked road is the only monument to it.

ON WHAT HAPPENED HERE: Two events happened at this spot days apart. First: Elnara's weapon convoy was struck, the impact stone was made, Blackrazor was carried north. The weapon convoy carried no dust; the owlbear, already contaminated from an earlier Sorel Vane shipment that broke open in the ravine months prior, attacked it the way it had been attacking anything that moved through the Thicket, out of aggression and altered instinct, not because it scented the cargo. Then: the owlbear came south again and struck Blink's Coach B, this time finding the dust its hunger had been hunting. The fresh wreck and the old scars overlies each other. The party is reading both at once, though they have no way to know that yet. The trail leads toward the owlbear whether or not the party intends it to.

AREA 2: RAVINE WAGON WRECK

The ravine opens without warning, the forest floor simply ends and the ground drops fifteen feet to a rubble-strewn stream bed below. The smell hits before the sight does: blood, wet clay, the sharp alchemical bite of something that does not belong in a forest. Coach B lies split at the bottom, one wheel still suspended over the stream, turning slowly in the current. Boxes have burst open across the stone. White powder clings to every surface it touched. Below, something is moving.

THE RAVINE

The ravine runs roughly east-west, fifteen feet deep at this crossing, its walls steep clay and exposed root. A shallow stream, six inches deep, cold, cuts the stone floor. Three wrecks occupy the ravine floor, and they are not the same age. The fresh one, Coach B, dominates: the coach body has split along its spine, both axles broken, the driver's bench thrown thirty feet east. The mules are dead, still partially in harness, their coats dusted white where they fell. Behind and beneath the Coach B debris, partially obscured by days of mud accumulation and the larger wreck's spread, is an older ruin: a smaller, unmarked transport vehicle, no livery, no commercial strapping, the timber grey and swollen with a week of stream-wet. The second wreck settled deeper into the ravine floor and the stream has begun to flow around it. It has been here longer than Coach B by several days at minimum. To the west, half-buried under the stream mud and barely distinguishable from the surrounding rock, bleached splinters

of an unmarked vehicle frame protrude from the bank, older than either wreck by months, with no livery and no fittings remaining, the timber so long submerged it has gone pale and soft.

DESCENT. The east wall has a natural ledge eight feet down and enough root-handholds to climb without a roll. The west wall is sheer clay. Dropping directly from the rim is a 15-foot fall (1d6 damage; Dexterity check to halve). Characters in plate or heavy encumbrance must make a Dexterity check or take full damage regardless.

LIGHT. The ravine bottom is shadowed at any hour. The powder on the wagon debris and the stream-soaked mud creates a faint ambient shimmer, not enough to see by, but enough to notice.

WHAT'S HERE

WHELM. The warhammer is at the base of the east wall, buried to half its head in the stream-side mud where it came to rest after striking the road above (Area 1) and rolling east into the ravine in the days since. A character searching the ravine floor finds it automatically in one turn. A dwarf character within thirty feet detects it without searching, not through any magical sense, but as an almost physical discomfort, like a tuning fork struck near bone. The hammer is cold to the touch regardless of how long it is held. It is not currently warm to any wielder. It will not refuse to be carried, but it will not cooperate with non-dwarves: attack rolls made with Whelm by a non-dwarf suffer a -2 penalty until the hammer has been formally introduced to its new wielder over the course of a day's use (referee's discretion). *This is where Area 1's cold impact stone was pointing.*

THE THREE DEAD. Three of Sorel Vane's crew lie in the wreck. The owlbear killed them during the attack that destroyed Coach B, claw marks across torso and head, consistent with the beast's track evidence at Area 1. They still have their equipment: leather armour, shortswords, belt pouches with 3d6 silver and 1d6 gold between them. One carries a folded paper: a partial ledger in coded shorthand (Intelligence check to partially decode) that references a rendezvous at *the camp* and a contact identified only as *K*. The ledger lists a quantity, *eight (8) tubes, confirmed*, and a date that was last night.

THE DUST CACHE. One crate survived the impact largely intact, its iron strapping holding. Its false bottom, a second layer of bladder-skin lining over a wax-sealed compartment, contained eight ceramic tubes of white plume dust, stoppered with beeswax. A character who disassembles the crate rather than simply opening it finds the hidden compartment

automatically. The exterior of the crate bears Blink Tinderflip's shipping mark (the stylised T in a circle). Two tubes remain in the compartment, both cracked open and emptied, Mave found the cache before the party arrived and cracked one tube for herself, then watched Dort crack a second. The remaining six intact tubes are in Mave's pack, not the crate.

THE REVOCATION. Wedged beneath the collapsed packing frame of the older vehicle, half-buried in stream mud: a lead-lined wooden case, its wax seal intact, roughly the size of a large book. The lead lining is why the false Keraptis has not found it through scrying, he knows it exists and cannot locate it. The case is heavier than it looks. A character who searches the older vehicle's debris specifically, rather than the Coach B wreck, which dominates attention, finds it automatically in one turn. Mave and Dort did not find it; it is under the older vehicle's debris, not the Coach B wreck, and they had no reason to search something that predates their operation by a week.

A character who breaks the seal finds a flat stone tablet, eighteen inches by twelve, inscribed on both faces in a cramped and precise archaic hand. The language is Old Suloise; a Magic-User or a character with knowledge of ancient languages can read it with a successful Intelligence check, though full comprehension requires an hour's study. The gist, available on a partial success: a formal declaration in the first person, voiding the legitimacy of all mind-copies made after a specific date. The full text, on a full success or after study: the declaration is Keraptis's own, written before his death. It names the failsafe conditions under which each copy of his mind would collapse, the original built a killswitch into his copies and committed it to stone. The false Keraptis has been looking for this document for the duration of his operation in the Thicket. The dust, the owlbear, the smuggling network: at some level, all of it was a search.

BLINK'S MANIFEST. Pinned under the splintered driver's bench of Coach B: a water-damaged but legible consignment document in Blink Tinderflip's handwriting. It covers two coaches and two consignments. Coach A: *Wave, sealed cask, handle with care.* Coach B: *Correspondence case, oilskin-wrapped, deliver intact.* No further names. The manifest is addressed to *E. Forger, Ringstown*, which is one of Elnara's cover names.

THE WEAPON-CONVOY MANIFEST. Inside the older vehicle, wedged beneath the collapsed packing frame: a second document, older and more water-damaged, written in a different hand, precise, educated, the kind of handwriting that belongs to someone who files reports. It lists three items. *W., secured, iron band. Wrapped head, do not remove wrapping. BR., secured. Do not unwrap under any circumstances. R., cased, lead seal. Do not open.* No shipping name. No commercial mark. No

address. A routing note in a different ink at the bottom reads: *Proceed north. Staging confirmed. , E.* The handwriting on that last line is not the same as the manifest body.

THE ENCOUNTER: MAVE ROON AND DORT

Two of Sorel Vane's crew came to the wreck ahead of the party, looking for the scattered cargo. They found the dust cache. They sampled it.

MAVE ROON took a single dose moments ago, she is still coming up on it, sharp-eyed and fast. She has positioned herself behind the overturned coach body with the remaining six intact tubes in her pack. She will treat any approach as a threat to the cache. She is not irrational, she can be talked to, but her threat assessment is distorted and she will draw steel without hesitation if anyone reaches for her pack. She knows the cache belongs to Sorel Vane and that handing it over represents a significant professional failure. She also, quietly, does not want to stop feeling the way she currently feels.

DORT took a second dose perhaps a minute ago when the first wore off. He is in backlash, rolling badly across multiple symptoms simultaneously. He is scratching the letter K into the ravine wall with his belt knife in an obsessive, methodical pattern, not one K, but dozens, filling a four-foot section of exposed clay. He periodically turns to announce to no one: *"I am Keraptis. I found it first."* He may attack the party, or Mave, or simply ignore both; his attention flickers between the wall and the nearest warm body. When he attacks, he is effective, the dust-enhanced reflexes survive even as the mind fragments.

IF MAVE IS WOUNDED she may grab a third tube from her pack and attempt to consume it, which the referee should telegraph clearly, Mave is visibly reaching into the pack, and allow the party one action to interrupt. A character adjacent to Mave may make a Dexterity check to grab the pack strap or a Strength check to pin her arm before she accesses the tube; neither requires any special ability, only position and initiative. If she takes a third dose, her bonuses persist but the referee should roll immediately on the backlash table at end of next round regardless of the duration, triple-dosing accelerates the crash.

IF DORT IS RESTRAINED OR KNOCKED UNCONSCIOUS, Mave loses her nerve and may attempt to bargain. She knows Sorel Vane's name, the location of the logging camp (Area 3), and that the rendezvous was supposed to happen the previous night. She does not know why Sorel has not appeared.

MAVE ROON (*dust-enhanced*)

FIGHTER 2, Human, Female AC 5 (*leather + Dex*), HD 2, HP 13 STR 15, DEX 14, CON 12 ATTACKS 1/round: shortsword +4 to hit, 1d6+3 damage (*dust bonuses included*) SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 12, Wands 13, Paralyzation 14, Breath 15, Spells 15 (+2 *from dust*) MORALE 10 (+2 *from dust*) EQUIPMENT Leather armour, shortsword, pack with 6 doses white plume dust, 14 gp, partial map of south approach trails

Without dust: +2 to hit, +1 damage, morale 8. Saving throw targets without dust: Death/Poison 14, Wands 15, Paralyzation 16, Breath 17, Spells 17.

TACTICS: Uses the wrecked coach body as cover (AC 3 against missile fire from above). Will not break and run while she has the cache; will attempt to flee east along the ravine floor if reduced below 4 hp.

DORT (*deep backlash*)

FIGHTER 2, Human, Male AC 6 (*leather*), HD 2, HP 11 STR 13, DEX 11, CON 12, INT 9, WIS 8, CHA 9 ATTACKS 1/round: handaxe +2 to hit, 1d6+1 damage SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 14, Wands 15, Paralyzation 16, Breath 17, Spells 17 MORALE (*ignore morale; Dort does not check morale and does not flee*) EQUIPMENT Leather armour, handaxe, belt knife, 7 sp

Backlash symptoms active: Dort suffers a -1 penalty to AC against attacks he does not see coming (referee's discretion) due to fractured attention. He will spend his first action each round not attacking if there is an exposed surface within reach to carve. On a roll of 1 on his attack die, he has struck the ravine wall instead of his target.

TACTICS: Dort does not have tactics. He moves toward the nearest perceived threat and attacks. He does not use cover. He will not stop when reduced to 1 hp, he must be knocked unconscious or restrained. Sleep spells, paralysis, and other incapacitation work normally on Dort. He remains inert under these effects but resumes his behaviour the moment incapacitation ends unless he is also physically restrained.

Referee note: Dort's double dose produced multiple failed saves, treat him as having rolled results 1 and 4 on the backlash table simultaneously. The module explicitly acknowledges this is exceptional; double-dosing stacks backlash rolls.

REFEREE NOTES

ON WHAT HAPPENED HERE: Two separate events converge in this ravine. First: Elnara's weapon convoy was attacked at the forest edge road (Area 1) by the owlbear, which had found an earlier dust cache and was already altered. The convoy's vehicle rolled or was dragged into the ravine; the operatives were killed and their bodies removed by the silk-wearing operative

(Varek Sorn , see NPC section) before anyone else arrived. Whelm fell from the vehicle into the stream-side mud. Blackrazor was carried north by the owlbear. Second, days later: Coach B was struck by the owlbear on the road during the session opening, and its debris ended up in the ravine. The road at the forest edge runs near the lip of the ravine's western approach; the impact drove Coach B sideways over the edge and down the clay slope to the stream bed. Of the six smugglers Sorel had positioned as outriders, three died in the Coach B chaos, two in the fall, one from the owlbear's follow-through. Mave and Dort survived by being thrown clear. A sixth smuggler fled south and is unaccounted for, Sorel knows someone ran but not who. Mave and Dort reached the ravine floor and found the Coach B wreck intact enough to search. They did not examine the older vehicle thoroughly; the larger, fresher wreck drew their attention. They have been here roughly an hour.

ON THE WEAPON CONVOY: Elnara authorized the movement of Whelm, Blackrazor, and the Revocation north through the Thicket in a single convoy, acting under Shield Lands intelligence backing she does not advertise. The weapons were bait , place what the false Keraptis most wants within reach of his network and close the trap when he emerges. The Revocation was the real prize being moved to a safer stronghold, away from the mountain and away from whatever intelligence network the false Keraptis had been running in Ringstown. The convoy was unmarked and routed through the Thicket to avoid the main road. It failed before reaching its staging point. The owlbear, already altered by earlier dust exposure, struck the convoy at the forest edge, killed the operatives, and the silk-wearing operative removed the bodies before anyone else arrived. Elnara has told no one in Ringstown. If the party shows her the weapon-convoy manifest, she will recognise the routing note in her own hand and will not confirm it is hers. She will add 10 gp to the commission without explanation and say nothing further. That response is, itself, a confirmation.

ON WHELM'S PERSONALITY: Whelm does not speak, rattle, or glow. Its personality is expressed entirely through temperature and weight. In the hands of a dwarf, it is comfortable, almost familiar, the way a well-balanced tool feels. In any other hands, it is subtly wrong: the balance seems slightly off, the grip slightly cold, as though the hammer is merely tolerating the arrangement. This is not mechanical. Do not make it mechanical. Let it be unsettling without a rule attached.

ON THE DUST CACHE: Eight doses is a significant haul. Two are already gone (consumed by Mave and Dort). The remaining six represent real value to Elnara as evidence and to Sorel Vane as a professional loss. If the party attempts to sell

the cache in Ringstown, Kelpwick at Thingizzard's Sundries will offer 5 gp per dose and ask no questions. Elnara will confiscate the cache as evidence if shown it, without payment, unless the party negotiates first.

ON THE CODED LEDGER: A successful Intelligence check reads it as: a number of doses, a destination (*the camp*), a contact (*K*), and a date that has now passed. The *K* here does not refer to Keraptis. It is a shorthand used in the network for the contact at the camp , whose identity the referee should leave undefined until Area 3. The party may assume it refers to Keraptis; this is wrong but useful misinformation.

ON THE MANIFESTS: Two documents, two operations. Blink's manifest covers only his cargo: Wave and the correspondence case, addressed to E. Forger. If the party recognises E. Forger and connects it to Elnara, they have leverage she will be uncomfortable with. She will not confirm or deny the name; adds 10 gp to the commission without explanation and says nothing further. The weapon-convoy manifest is a separate document from a separate operation, and its routing note signed *E*. is the more dangerous revelation: it connects Elnara not just to the cargo chain but to the plan that created the owlbear problem. Elnara will react to these two documents very differently if the party distinguishes between them.

ON PACE: The encounter with Mave and Dort should feel dangerous and slightly chaotic, Dort's unpredictability is the engine. A party that handles this efficiently has earned the information Mave carries. A party that handles it messily may find themselves short on resources before Area 3. This is the adventure's first real test of party decision-making, not just combat capacity.

ON THE COACH A VARIANT: The session intro includes a branching outcome where Coach A (carrying Wave) may be struck instead of Coach B. Area 2 is written for the Coach B outcome. If Coach A was struck: the dead outriders, dust cache, and manifests in this ravine remain unchanged , they belong to the weapon convoy and to Coach B's separate impact, not to which of Blink's coaches was hit on the road. Wave becomes the first recovery objective on the road north, findable at Area 1 or in the forest verge. The only element to adjust is the "Coach B lies split at the bottom" read-aloud , if Coach A was struck, Coach B was never destroyed, and the party may know this. The weapon convoy wreck, the Revocation, and Whelm are here regardless.

AREA 3: LOGGING CAMP

The logging camp looks as if a storm developed opinions about it. Tarps hang in strips from their poles, split logs are scattered through the mud in patterns that suggest both panic and physics, and deep claw marks run up the watchtower supports from ground level to fifteen feet in a single continuous gouge. The cookfire still smolders under a pot kicked half over in the mud. Somewhere in the wreckage, someone is moving, careful, practiced movement, the kind that belongs to a person who doesn't want to be seen.

CAMP LAYOUT

The camp occupies a cleared quarter-acre of forest floor, running roughly north-south, with the Thicket pressing in on three sides. The south approach is the clearest path in; the north end of the camp opens onto a trampled area of felled timber before the trees close again. Five structures remain, in varying states of intact:

THE BUNKHOUSE. The camp's main sleeping structure, a long low building of rough-cut timber, took the owlbear's first impact on its northeast corner. That corner is demolished; the remaining three walls are standing but bowed. The bunks inside have been thrown from their frames. Three loggers' personal effects are scattered across the floor: a good pair of boots, a carved pipe, a letter in trade tongue that was never finished. Nothing worth taking. But the details reward a character who stops to look.

THE WATCHTOWER. The north end of the camp. Fifteen feet of notched timber, the upper platform intact, the two support posts on the south face gouged by the same claw sweep that tore the bunkhouse corner. The ladder rungs are intact. From the platform, the party can see the felled timber area to the north and the tree line where the owlbear exited. The view north is the clearest sight line in the area and worth the climb: two large pine trunks are knocked flat in the direction of Area 5, a trail no tracking roll is needed to read.

THE SUPPLY SHED. South end of camp. The padlock hangs open in the hasp, not broken, not cut, but picked clean, the tumblers visibly scored by a tool. Whoever emptied the shed did not bother to relock it on the way out; they were in a hurry or simply did not care. Inside: logging tools, lamp oil, a quarter-cask of salted provisions, and, notably, an empty space in the centre of the floor where something large was kept and recently removed. The outline in the dust is rectangular, the right size for a shipping crate. Whatever was stored here was

taken before the owlbear arrived, not during or after.

THE COOKFIRE STATION. The pot kicked into the mud still contains a day-old stew. Two tin cups on the ground nearby. The fire was recently stoked, within the hour, which means someone was trying to stay warm, which means someone was here long enough to want comfort.

THE FELLED TIMBER YARD. North of the watchtower, not really a structure: a cleared area where trunks are stacked and sectioned. Two of the stacks have been knocked over. The owlbear came through here on its way south into the camp, and again on its way north leaving. The prints are enormous and easy to follow. The trail north leads directly toward Area 5.

WHAT HAPPENED HERE

The attack was mid-afternoon, not at night. The logging crew, seven men, was working the timber yard when the owlbear came south from the tree line at speed. It struck the bunkhouse, swept the north fence posts, crossed the camp in three strides, and was gone north again in under two minutes. Four of the seven loggers fled south and reached the main road. Two hid under the supply shed flooring and emerged after dark. One, Pell, the actual camp foreman, fled south with the others and is now in Ringstown. He is not talking about what he saw, but he is there.

Kael Vorst. Near the bunkhouse wreckage, propped against the south wall in a position suggesting he sat down and did not get up: a man in his middle years, well-fed for a logger, in clothes that are almost right for the work. His wounds are consistent with the owlbear's claw pattern. A character with healing experience (Cleric, Druid, Ranger, or a successful Intelligence check) who examines the body carefully notices an inconsistency: the deepest wound, the one that killed him, enters from the back, angled slightly downward, the profile of a blade thrust from a standing person to a kneeling one. The owlbear's claws are not blades. *Kael Vorst was stabbed in the back during the chaos and the claw wounds were added afterward, either by the beast or by whoever killed him.* The killer is gone. The instrument, a narrow blade, is not on the body or in the immediate area.

Kael Vorst is the K-contact from the Area 2 ledger. He was not a logger. He was sent here to collect the crates and move them north. He arrived two days ago posing as a replacement foreman; the real foreman, recognising something was wrong, found an excuse to be in Ringstown. Kael's body has no identification. His belt pouch contains 34 gp, a sealed vial of the standard white plume dust antitoxin (the same formula Kelpwick sells), and a small polished obsidian disc, blank on both faces, warm to the touch in a way that has nothing to do

with sun or body heat.

WHAT'S HERE

THE OBSIDIAN DISC (on Kael's body): No inscription, no markings, warm. A Magic-User or Cleric who holds it and concentrates (one round, uninterrupted) senses faint directed intention, not a spell, not psionic, but structured. Like a key that has been near its lock. It does not appear in Area 7 (the Riddle Cave) by coincidence.

THE SUPPLY SHED'S EMPTIED SPACE: Whatever was stored here before the owlbear arrived is not in the camp. A wax seal fragment in the dust matches Blink Tinderflip's shipping mark. The party has now found this mark in at least three places: Area 1 (the broken crate), Area 2 (the false-bottom crate), and here. Someone moved this consignment before the attack, possibly Kael himself, possibly whoever killed him. If the party visited Area 5 before Area 3, they have already found the mark a fourth time; the synthesis moment still lands here, Area 3 is the location where human context (Sorel's knowledge of Tinderflip) connects the mark to the supply chain, regardless of discovery order.

PELL'S ABSENCE EXPLAINS THE PICKED LOCK. The supply shed key is on Pell's keyring. Pell is in Ringstown. Whoever emptied the shed before the attack did not have the key and picked the lock instead, the scored tumblers confirm it. A character who asks why a professional would bother picking a lock when they could simply ask the foreman has the right instinct: whoever emptied the shed could not ask the foreman without revealing themselves. This is when the timeline becomes interesting.

THE OWLBEAR TRAIL NORTH: From the timber yard, two flattened pines point north like an arrow. No tracking roll is required to follow this to Area 5. Characters who follow the trail also notice, at the edge of the tree line, a cluster of fresh K-marks carved into three adjacent pines, not by the owlbear's claws (the angle is wrong, the lines too deliberate) but by a human hand with a small blade. They were not here before the attack. Someone came to the camp after the owlbear left and carved them.

THE ENCOUNTER: SOREL VANE AND CREW

Sorel Vane arrived at the camp four hours ago with four of his people. He found the wreck, found Kael's body, and has been waiting since. He is not waiting for the crates, he knows by now they are not coming, he is waiting for something to make sense of this, which it has not yet done. One of the four, Orn,

has not returned since leaving to check the treeline K-marks; see Referee Notes.

His crew is spread through the camp: one watching the south approach from behind the bunkhouse, one in the watchtower, one, Pirrel, sitting near the cookfire doing something with her belt knife that she does not appear to notice she is doing. The person the party detected moving at the start of this area is Sorel himself, circling the supply shed again.

FIRST CONTACT. Sorel is not hiding, exactly, but he is not announcing himself either. When the party enters the camp, he will let them get roughly to the cookfire before stepping out of cover and addressing them: *"You're not loggers. You're not Kael's people. So, who sent you, and what are you carrying?"* He is evaluating threat, not picking a fight. His hand is near his crossbow but not on it.

IF THE PARTY HAS THE CODED LEDGER FROM AREA 2: Sorel recognises his own shorthand immediately and his expression closes. He will ask, very quietly, what happened to Mave and Dort. He will not attack unless the party answers in a way that confirms they killed his people for the cache alone. If the party handled Mave and Dort non-lethally or explains the situation, Sorel goes quiet, not calculating, not relieved, just still. If Mave is dead, he says, eventually: *"Mave was good people."* He does not ask for details. He does not ask the party to apologise. The quiet lasts long enough to become uncomfortable, and then he nods once and the professional mask comes back. But it does not sit quite right over whatever is underneath it. Only after that does he become calculating.

IF THE PARTY MENTIONS BLINK TINDERFLIP: Sorel's jaw tightens. He will not confirm or deny the name in front of his crew. He will say: *"That's a name I'd rather not say out loud in the Thicket. Come inside."* He is willing to speak privately.

IF THE PARTY SHOWS THE MANIFEST FROM AREA 2 NAMING "E. FORGER": Sorel laughs, a short, unhappy sound, and says: *"Elnara. Of course she was already moving pieces."* He has now confirmed the party's connection to Elnara, and the dynamic shifts. He is not afraid of Elnara exactly, but he respects her competence and that respect modulates his options.

WHAT SOREL WILL TRADE FOR SAFE PASSAGE SOUTH:

Sorel does not want to fight the party. He wants to leave the Thicket alive and with enough distance from this operation that when it comes apart, and it is coming apart, his name is not at the centre of it. He will offer the following information freely if the party agrees not to bring his name to Elnara:

- The dust is manufactured, not harvested, there is a laboratory. He has never seen it but has been told it is underground, north of the Thicket, connected to the

mountain.

- His employer above Blink Tinderflip uses the title *the Inheritor*. Sorel has never met or seen this person. All contact went through Kael. Kael is dead.
- The K-shorthand in the coded ledger is not a reference to Keraptis, it was Kael's personal mark, a professional signature. Sorel did not choose it. In retrospect, *yes, I see how that looks*.
- The emptied supply shed was Kael's doing, Kael had a separate consignment already in place when the crew arrived, and he moved it himself before the owlbear hit. Sorel does not know where it went.
- The obsidian disc, if shown to Sorel: he has seen one before. Kael wore one around his neck at their first meeting and later stopped wearing it. He does not know what they are.

WHAT SOREL WILL NOT TRADE, AT ANY PRICE: The identity of the buyers in Critwall from the partial ledger in Area 2. Those are people with long memories and Sorel has a family in Critwall.

PIRREL. Sorel's fourth crew member, sitting at the cookfire, is carving something into the log she sits on. She has been doing this for two hours. She is carving the letter K, over and over, in a grid-like pattern, filling each previous row before starting a new one. She is not in combat distress, she will fight if the camp is attacked, and she is still effective, but her eyes are slightly wrong, white visible around the iris. If the party includes a healer or anyone who has seen advanced dust exposure, a Wisdom check recognises this as mid-stage compulsion. Sorel knows something is wrong with her; he does not know it is the dust. He thinks it's shock. He is wrong. If the party explains what is happening to her, Sorel's cooperative threshold drops significantly.

SOREL VANE

FIGHTER 4, Human, Male AC 5 (*studded leather + Dex*), HD 4, HP 27 ATTACKS 1/round: short sword +3 to hit, 1d6+1 damage; or light crossbow +4 to hit, 1d4+1 damage (range 60 ft./120 ft./180 ft.) SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 13, Wands 14, Paralyzation 15, Breath 16, Spells 16 MORALE 10 (*drops to 7 if two crew members are down*) STR 12, INT 13, WIS 9, DEX 15, CON 11, CHA 14 EQUIPMENT Studded leather, short sword, light crossbow, 20 bolts, 22 gp, a written contact address in Critwall (encoded, inside boot lining)

TACTICS: Sorel fights with professional economy, he identifies the most dangerous target and addresses it, uses cover instinctively, and will attempt to disengage and run south if reduced below 8 hp. He does not sacrifice himself. He will call his crew off if he decides to negotiate.

SMUGGLER CREW (TAV, HESSIG)

FIGHTER 1, Human, Mixed AC 7 (*leather*), HD 1, HP 5, 6 ATTACKS 1/round: short sword or hand axe +1 to hit, 1d6 damage SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 14, Wands 15, Paralyzation 16, Breath 17, Spells 17 MORALE 8 (*with Sorel present; drops to 5 if Sorel falls or flees*)

Note: A fourth crew member, Orn, departed before the party arrives and is found dead in Area 6.

TACTICS: They follow Sorel's lead. If he negotiates, they stand down. If he runs, they run. They will not fight to the death for Blink Tinderflip's shipping schedule.

PIRREL (*mid-stage dust compulsion*)

FIGHTER 1, Human, Female AC 7 (*leather*), HD 1, HP 6 ATTACKS 1/round: short sword +1 to hit, 1d6 damage SAVING THROWS as crew above MORALE 12 (*does not check morale; backlash compulsion overrides fear response*)

Note: Pirrel is not enhanced, the active dose wore off hours ago. She found a loose tube in the camp debris while searching for signs of Kael and dosed herself before Sorel could stop her; he did not realise what she had taken until the compulsion started. The tube had rolled under the shed floorboards when Kael emptied the consignment, one tube unaccounted for in his own careful work. She is in the compulsion phase: she will fight without hesitation if the camp is attacked, but between combats she returns to carving. She cannot be reasoned out of this by ordinary persuasion. If the party has the dust antitoxin from Kael's body and administers it, her compulsion clears over 1d4 turns. Sorel will be quietly, genuinely grateful.

REFEREE NOTES

ON SOREL'S POSITION DURING THE ATTACK: Sorel was at the logging camp when the attack happened, he had gone ahead to meet Kael and coordinate the pickup. His outriders (including Mave and Dort) were running the road escort. When no one arrived by the morning after, he began to realise something had gone wrong. He sent Orn back toward the road to check; Orn is how he knew someone had fled the road attack, though not who.

ON KAEV VORST'S KILLER: The party may not discover the murder during this visit; it depends on whether anyone examines the body carefully. Do not volunteer the inconsistency, reward it if found. The killer was not Sorel (he found the body; the timeline holds up under questioning). The killer came from the north, used the owlbear as cover, and left north again. This is someone with operational knowledge of both the attack's timing and the camp's role in the supply

chain. The obsidian disc is the only thread, and it leads to Area 7.

ON HOW ORN WAS SEPARATED FROM THE CREW: Among the K-marks carved into the three pines at the north treeline, the operative left a sealed note wedged into a bark split at eye level, addressed to Orn by name. The note instructed him to follow the marked trail north and collect a package that had been left for him. The fact that the operative knew Orn's name specifically, not Sorel's, not Tav's or Hessig's, suggests the Inheritor's network has detailed intelligence on Sorel's crew composition, a fact that should alarm Sorel considerably if the party tells him. The note is gone (Orn took it); only the empty bark split remains, visible to anyone who examines the K-marks closely. Sorel did not see Orn leave because Orn waited until Sorel was occupied before checking the treeline marks, he recognised the operative's signalling convention from prior jobs.

ON THE EMPTIED SUPPLY SHED: Whatever was in it is not findable in this adventure. It is a loose end pointing forward, to White Plume Mountain proper, if this adventure serves as a prologue. Leave it open. The wax seal fragment is evidence enough that Blink's network was using this location as a depot before the owlbear disrupted everything.

ON PIRREL'S HIDDEN TUBE. A character who searches Pirrel or notices her carving and investigates will find a wax-sealed ceramic tube in her boot. It is identical to the tubes from Area 2's cache. She does not know what it is, only that taking it felt right at the time. If the party uses this as leverage, returning it to Sorel or destroying it in front of Pirrel, it has no immediate mechanical effect, but Sorel's cooperative threshold drops significantly: he is watching the dust do to his crew what he has heard it does in stories, and someone taking it seriously is more than he expected.

ON SOREL AS AN ONGOING RESOURCE: If the party treats Sorel fairly, takes his information, honors the safe passage agreement, maybe even gets Pirrel treated, he becomes a useful contact in Critwall. He knows the buyer network. He has no loyalty to the Inheritor, only to being alive. A referee running this as a campaign entry point should note his address in Critwall and let Sorel be a thread the party can pull later.

ON PIRREL: If the party does not treat her and Sorel decides to head south, he will take her with him. She will get worse. By the time they reach the forest edge she will be unresponsive to anything except the compulsion. Sorel cannot make himself leave her there. He will ask the party, one more time, if there is anything that can help. This is not a trap. It is a man watching his crew come apart and not knowing why.

ON THE K-MARKS AT THE TREE LINE: These were not made by any of Sorel's crew (Sorel will confirm this, and none of his people are missing a blade with the right profile). They

were not made by the owlbear. Someone with intent came to this camp after the attack and marked the trail north as though directing something, or someone, to follow it. The owlbear is controlled more than the party may yet realise.

ON THE PATH TO THE GLADE: A game path branches west from the main north trail roughly a hundred yards south of the camp. It is not obvious from the road but is visible to anyone who slows down and looks. It leads, eventually, toward the glade described in Area 4. Old Brindle came from this direction.

ON OLD BRINDLE: If the party rolled encounter #17 on the wandering table and Brindle appeared, he may have passed through this area. If the referee wishes, Old Brindle has left a small ward at the north edge of the timber yard, a stone circle, the rocks placed in a druidic pattern that a Ranger or Druid recognises as a slow ward against corrupted movement. It has been partially broken, the stones kicked aside. The disruption is recent. Brindle is ahead of the party, moving fast.

AREA 4: DUST POOL GLADE

The forest opens into a clearing that should be beautiful and is not. The glade is the right size and shape for beauty, a gap in the canopy, afternoon light coming through in columns, a shallow basin at the centre ringed with smooth stones, but everything aimed at the basin is wrong. The flowers lean toward it on stems bent at angles that have nothing to do with the light. The bark on the surrounding trees has split open along lines that, at a certain distance, almost resolve into letters. The pool itself glows white-blue even in direct sunlight, and the smell rising from it is cold, bitter, and faintly sweet in a way that makes the back of the throat tighten. Nothing is making noise. No insects. No wind. No birds. The silence is absolute and has been for some time.

THE GLADE

The clearing is roughly forty feet across, almost circular, as though something burned or cleared it long ago and the forest never fully reclaimed it. The treeline is tight on all sides, and the ground between the treeline and the pool basin, perhaps twenty feet in any direction, is wrong in ways the party can identify if they look:

THE VEGETATION. Every plant in the glade is oriented toward the pool. Not leaning, *oriented*, the way a compass points north, with the same indifference to what should be influencing it. Flowers have opened on the wrong faces of their stems. Two saplings near the east edge have grown in

arcs, their trunks curved, their tops pointing at the basin. A patch of moss on the north stones has died in a rough circle, the dead fringe still reaching inward. A character who examines the bark of the surrounding trees closely finds partial letters, not carved, grown into the bark during the tree's own expansion. They are not consistent across trees. They are not quite readable. They have a K in them, always.

THE SILENCE. There are no insects, no birds, no small-creature rustling. A Ranger or Druid who stands at the treeline for one round understands instinctively that this silence is not fear, animals are not hiding here, they have not been here in some time. Something about the pool's chemistry has altered the environment at a fundamental level. The party's animals, if any, will refuse to enter the clearing. They cannot be forced; they will injure themselves rather than cross the treeline.

THE COLD. The glade is three to five degrees colder than the surrounding forest. There is no meteorological explanation. The cold intensifies near the pool, within five feet of the basin, breath fogs. The stones around the basin rim have frost on them, despite the season.

THE POOL

The basin is twelve feet across, the water perhaps eighteen inches at its deepest. The glow is consistent, white-blue, faint but unmistakable in shadow, and still visible in direct daylight as a shimmer at odds with normal water's behaviour. The water itself is clear, and through it the stone basin floor is visible. The floor of the basin is coated in a thin white deposit, crystallised dust that has settled and hardened into a layer perhaps half an inch thick. This is not algae or mineral deposit. A Magic-User who examines it (without touching) recognises it as residue from a prolonged magical contamination, the source running continuously into this water for long enough that the accumulation is structural.

THE CONTAMINATION'S SOURCE. The pool is fed by a spring from below. The spring is natural; the contamination is not. Old Brindle (if present) can explain, and a Ranger or Druid who examines the basin and succeeds on a Wisdom check understands: the dust is entering through the groundwater from the north, seeping through stone from something underground. It is not being produced here. The pool is an endpoint, not an origin. Destroying the pool cleans this location; it does not stop the source.

WHAT THE POOL DOES TO PEOPLE WHO TOUCH IT. A character who touches the water bare-handed must save versus spells or feel an immediate, pleasant warmth in the hand spreading up the arm, the dust's euphoric effect, delivered

transdermally at low dose. On a failed save, the character gains a mild compulsion to drink from the pool (save vs. Death/Poison to resist; refusing the compulsion is possible and costs no mechanical resource but should be described). A character who drinks gains the dust's combat benefits for 5 rounds (half duration, half dose) and must roll on the backlash table at the end, with a +2 bonus to the roll (making the severe results less likely but not impossible). Touching the water while wearing gloves: no effect. Wading into it barefoot: treat as two simultaneous bare-hand contacts.

WHAT THE POOL SHOWS. The water's surface does not reflect the sky correctly. A character who looks closely into the pool and succeeds on a Wisdom check (or simply stares for more than one round) notices the reflection showing something other than the canopy overhead, something darker, an impression of depth that has no source in the physical basin. If the false Keraptis is actively watching through the pool (referee's discretion; he watches during the cleansing rite automatically), the reflection briefly resolves into a face: narrow, patient, with the eyes of someone who has been waiting a very long time and is accustomed to it. The face does not react to being seen. It simply observes. Old Brindle will break contact immediately if he sees a character staring into the pool too long.

OLD BRINDLE

He is here. He has been here, without sleep, for over two days, driven back three nights ago when the owlbear came to drink and returned the following morning. He has not left the glade since.

Old Brindle is seated at the northwest edge of the basin on a flat stone he dragged in from the treeline. He has a druidic focus, a fork of ash wood, wrapped in cord, in his hands, and he is muttering. He looks up when the party enters the glade with the unhurried calm of a man who has been expecting them, which is approximately true: the forest does not speak to druids in words, but it indicates, and the indication has been toward the south for the past hour.

He is not well. Three nights ago the owlbear came to drink and its arrival disrupted the partial ward he had placed; the backlash cost him. He has 6 hit points remaining. He has used all his prepared spells except *cure light wounds* (1), which he is saving for an emergency. He is maintaining the partial ward on willpower alone, and willpower, as he will tell the party if asked, is not a renewable resource.

"I know what you want. You want me to tell you where the beast is. You want a map of the situation, a set of clear steps. So do I."

"The pool is not the source. It is a mouth. Whatever is upstream, north, underground, has been feeding this water for months, possibly longer. I can close the mouth. I have been trying to close the mouth. What I cannot do alone is hold it open long enough to finish the rite. The pool pushes back."

WHAT OLD BRINDLE KNOWS:

- The pool is a scrying conduit. Something intelligent is watching through it. He calls it *the voice in the water* and will not use the name Keraptis without visible reluctance; if the party uses it, he says: *"That name has weight. Don't use it carelessly near the pool."*
- The owlbear comes to this pool at night to drink. This is the cycle: the pool contaminates the creature, the creature's own dust-saturated body seeps into the water when it drinks, which intensifies the pool, which intensifies the creature's contamination. Three nights ago the owlbear was more contaminated than Old Brindle had ever seen it, and its visit fed the pool enough to break his partial ward.
- The cleansing rite will close the pool, kill the glow, neutralise the crystallised deposit, break the scrying connection. It will not stop the source. It will stop the owlbear's reinforcement cycle, which means the creature's dust level will slowly decrease rather than continuously increase. This gives the party a better chance at Area 5.
- The K-marks in the trees around the glade were not here when Old Brindle arrived. They appeared the morning after the owlbear's most recent visit. He does not know who made them. He has the same interpretation as the party should at this point: someone is directing the owlbear's movements, or at least marking them.
- He has known this pool since he was young, it was a clear spring and a good campsite when he first found it, close to fifty years ago. He watched it change this season, slowly at first, then faster. He does not say this unless asked, but if the party asks why he came here specifically rather than summoning help or waiting: *"I swam in it. When I was twenty-three and didn't know better."* A pause. *"You don't let something you've known go wrong without at least trying."*
- The rumour that he can call the owlbear off is false. *"I can speak to animals. The owlbear is no longer an animal in the way the word means. Something is riding in its head that is not animal and not natural. I spoke to it once. What answered me was not the beast."*

WHAT OLD BRINDLE WILL NOT SAY unless he trusts the party: he attempted to make contact with the voice in the water once, deliberately, to understand what he was dealing with. It answered. It knew his name. It knew his niece's name. (He has no niece, Yenna Brindle is his niece only in the same way the

town calls her that, by adoption of neighbourhood, but the voice knew the name, which means it has been watching Ringstown through the pool for some time.) He has not told Yenna any of this. He does not intend to.

THE CLEANSING RITE

Old Brindle can perform a druidic cleansing of the pool. He needs two things he cannot provide alone:

FIRST: AN ANCHOR. Something brought from outside the Thicket's contaminated zone, untouched by dust, naturally pure. The bark map from the north gate gnome qualifies (the gnome marked it before the contamination intensified; it carries her uncorrupted intention). A flask of water from the Ringstown well qualifies. Holy water from Brother Aldric at the shrine qualifies and is the most powerful option. A handful of earth from the road south of the treeline qualifies, if the party collected some before entering the Thicket. This requires the foresight to have gathered it at or before Area 1; it cannot be retrieved retroactively once inside the contaminated zone. If the party has none of these, Old Brindle has one: a sprig of heather from outside the Thicket, gathered at the forest edge before he entered two days ago. He brought it deliberately, knowing the rite would eventually need an anchor. It is slightly wilted but still intact and still qualifies. He offers it without hesitation the moment the party asks. A referee who worries this is too easy should consider that Old Brindle has been here for two days with 6 hit points specifically so that this rite can happen; the anchor was never the obstacle. The anchor is not destroyed by the rite; it is returned to its holder afterward, unchanged.

SECOND: SOMEONE TO HOLD THE CONNECTION OPEN. Old Brindle must complete the rite in one uninterrupted turn (ten rounds). During that turn, the pool will resist, it pushes back, attempting to break the druid's concentration. Old Brindle can hold concentration against ordinary distraction, but the pool's resistance manifests as a physical pressure: anyone within ten feet of the basin during the rite must save versus spells each round or feel a strong compulsion to break Old Brindle's focus (shout, grab his arm, flee the clearing). This is not a charm, it is environmental psychic pressure, and it affects the party regardless of their intentions. A character who fails their save must make a Wisdom check to override the compulsion; success is possible but costs an action. A character who chooses to *hold the pool's attention*, actively engaging with the water, staring into it, speaking to whatever is watching, can absorb the pressure on behalf of the group, but they will make eye contact with the voice in the water.

THE RITE'S COMPLETION. If Old Brindle finishes the rite uninterrupted:

- The pool's glow extinguishes. The white-blue light drains in a spiral over one round and is gone.
- The crystallised deposit on the basin floor goes grey and begins to dissolve.
- The cold disperses over one turn. The insects return within the hour.
- The owlbear's *K-Whispers* ability is suppressed for the remainder of the session, the pool was amplifying it, and without the pool the aura loses its range.
- Old Brindle collapses. He is not dead, but he is unconscious and will remain so for 1d4 hours. He cannot be roused early. He should be left somewhere safe.

IF THE RITE IS INTERRUPTED. The pool releases the held pressure in a burst. Everyone within thirty feet takes 2d6 cold damage (save versus breath for half). Old Brindle is thrown back and is at 0 hit points (dying; he can be stabilised). The pool's glow intensifies for 1d6 hours before returning to normal. The false Keraptis has seen the party clearly.

WHAT'S HERE

THE BASIN STONES. The smooth stones ringing the pool were placed deliberately, not deposited by water action. They are river stones from a source some distance north, a druid or ranger can identify them as mountain granite, not the local limestone. They are spaced at intervals consistent with a ritual circle predating the contamination by decades. Someone made this pool a sacred site before it was a scrying pool. The rite Old Brindle performs is closing something that was opened by someone else, a long time ago.

THE BONE PILE. At the east edge of the glade, half-hidden by the leaning vegetation: a low mound of bones. Mixed species, deer, fox, boar, and several that are identifiable as gnoll. All clean, well-picked, arranged rather than scattered. Animals come to the pool and do not always leave. The most recent bones (a deer) are perhaps a week old. The oldest (the gnoll) are years old and slightly bleached. The gnoll bones predate the owlbear's corruption and suggest the pool has had some draw since long before the dust.

OLD BRINDLE'S CAMP. A rolled blanket against the northwest treeline, a clay pot with cold herb tea, a drawstring pouch with three berries (plumberries, naturally grown, non-contaminated, he gathered them on his way in before the contamination had reached the southern tree line). The plumberries are not medicinal; they are Old Brindle's food. A character who eats them without asking should have this noted but not punished.

THE VIEW NORTH AT DUSK. From the centre of the glade, looking north through the canopy gap, on any clear evening: a plume of pale smoke is visible above the tree line, far north. At dusk specifically, when the light is certain angles, the smoke briefly takes the shape of a face, not rendered carefully, not detailed, but unmistakeable as a face, turned south, watching. It does not linger. Old Brindle has seen it every evening he has been here. He does not comment on it unless asked. *"It has always been there. We just did not always look north at dusk."*

REFEREE NOTES

ON AVOIDING THE POOL'S PRESSURE: A party that positions all members outside ten feet of the basin removes the psychic pressure entirely, the pool only pushes back through living creatures near enough to feel it. The rite then proceeds without save requirements and Old Brindle succeeds automatically. This is a valid strategy. What it removes is the dramatic beat: no one holds the pool's attention, no one makes eye contact with the false Keraptis, and no one carries that knowledge forward. A referee should not volunteer this possibility, but should honour it if the table figures it out.

ON THE POOL AS A PACING TOOL. This is the adventure's breathing room, a place of atmosphere and revelation rather than combat. After the violence of Area 2 and the social pressure of Area 3, the party should feel the weight of what they have walked into. Old Brindle is useful precisely because he is exhausted: he knows things and is too tired to be coy about them. Let him talk. Reward the party for listening.

ON THE VOICE IN THE WATER. If a character chooses to hold the pool's attention during the rite and makes eye contact with the false Keraptis, describe what they see briefly and without explanation: a face, a sense of vast underground space, the impression of being studied the way a naturalist studies a specimen. The false Keraptis does not speak during this contact, he is observing, not recruiting. He now knows this character's face. This has no mechanical effect in this adventure, but a referee running into White Plume Mountain should note which character it was.

ON OLD BRINDLE'S RECOVERY. After the rite, he sleeps in the glade for 1d4 hours. When he wakes, he will tell the party where the owlbear's hollow is (Area 5, north through the timber yard; he scouted it before beginning the pool vigil and knows what is inside). He will also say: *"The beast came here to drink because it could not help itself. Whatever is in it is not its fault. I could not save it. Perhaps you can."* He does not mean kill it, necessarily. He does not know if there is another option. He suspects there is not, and he is sad about it. From the glade, the path east returns to the main north-south trail; from there, the

timber yard and Area 5 are directly north.

ON THE CYCLE BROKEN. If the party destroys or cleans the pool and then faces the owlbear at Area 5, the *K-Whispers* suppression is a meaningful advantage, it removes the area-effect save penalty that makes the owlbear's most dangerous ability chain. A party that skips this area and goes straight to Area 5 will face a harder fight. This is the reward for following the threads rather than going directly north.

ON RUMOUR #92 (*"If you destroy the glowing pool in the Thicket, the owlbear dies. The pool is its heart."*) This is false, and Old Brindle knows it. If the party tests this theory after the rite, Old Brindle says, without inflection: *"The pool was feeding it. Your heart is not your food."*

IF OLD BRINDLE DIES. Old Brindle is the adventure's primary source of context on the pool, the owlbear cycle, and the voice in the water. If he dies before sharing this information, the party is not blocked, they can discover the pool's purpose through examination, the K-marks in the glade, and the evidence in Area 5. What they lose is Old Brindle's emotional framing: the note that the owlbear was not at fault, that the pool's history predates the current corruption, and the offer of hope for the beast. The rite itself cannot be completed without him unless the party includes a druid of sufficient level (Druid 5 or higher) who can improvise the cleansing with a successful Wisdom check.

AREA 5: THORN-CHOKED HOLLOW

The trail north from the logging camp ends here, but you know that before you see the hollow, you know it from the smell, which is no longer something in the air but something the air is made of, cold and bitter and sweetly wrong. Then the ground drops away into a depression ringed by a wall of blackthorn eight feet high and three feet thick, grown so dense it might as well be stone. From inside comes a wet, rhythmic sound, not a breath exactly, but something with the cadence of breathing, the weight of it, the texture. And through a gap in the thorn wall you can see the floor of the hollow. The bones there are very clean. The white powder on the bones catches what little light comes through the canopy and glitters like scattered stars.

APPROACHING THE HOLLOW

The trail north from Area 3 requires no tracking roll. Two pine trunks are knocked flat and point the way like a compass needle. A character who has been following the adventure's threads arrives here already knowing what is at the end of it.

THE LAST FIFTY FEET. As the party closes on the hollow's perimeter, several things are observable without entering or making noise:

- THE SMELL INTENSIFIES. At thirty feet the bitter-sweet odour crosses from ambient to oppressive. Characters with sensitive smell (elves, certain racial abilities, or anyone explicitly paying attention) detect a secondary note beneath it: something animal and sick, like a large creature running a sustained fever.
- THE SILENCE. The forest's absolute quiet, established in Area 4, does not end at the glade's edge. It follows the party here. There are no birds anywhere in this part of the Thicket.
- THE K-MARKS. The exterior of the thorn wall, the face pointing toward the approaching party, has no K-marks. A character who circles the perimeter before entering will find that all the marks are carved on the *interior* face of the surrounding trees: visible from inside the hollow, invisible from outside. They were placed to be read by something already inside. The knife marks are precise, unhurried, deliberate. They are not fresh, they predate the owlbear's contamination by the scarring of the bark. Someone prepared this hollow before the beast arrived. It was not the owlbear.
- THE TORN SILK. Snagged on the exterior thorn wall at the northwest gap (the owlbear's primary exit): a strip of fabric, dark green, fine quality. Silk, or very close to it. Neither a logger nor a field smuggler wears silk this far north. It is not Sorel Vane's people. It was left by whoever came to carve the interior marks. The fabric is not fresh, it has been here through at least one rain, but it is not rotted. It has a faint cold quality to the touch, like the impact stone at Area 1. The thread that leads from this cloth leads north, to the mountain.
- WHELM'S RESPONSE. A character carrying Whelm notices the hammer becoming noticeably heavier and colder as they close on the hollow, not dramatically, not enough to impede movement, but unmistakable. By the time they reach the thorn wall, the hammer is as cold as the basin stones at Area 4 and its balance feels subtly wrong, as though it is orienting toward something. A dwarf character may feel this as a low vibration rather than temperature: the note struck in the impact stone at Area 1 is still ringing here, and this is where it came from.

THE HOLLOW

The depression is roughly forty feet across and eight feet deep, the walls made of packed earth, exposed root, and the interior face of the thorn ring. The floor is the flattened earth of long occupation: scraped bare in the centre, compressed by

weight and repeated movement, with deep parallel gouges radiating from the northwest corner (the owlbear's resting place) where claws have dragged across the ground in what might be pacing, or distress, or both.

THE THORN WALL. Three feet thick, eight feet high. The thorns are blackthorn and hawthorn, grown into a single interlocked mass. The owlbear passes through this freely, it has a body dense enough to push through without significant damage. For the party:

- Medium creatures can squeeze through any of the three visible gaps (northwest, southeast, north) in one round, taking 1d3 piercing damage from thorns.
- A character with 18 or more Strength can push a gap wide enough for one person to pass freely (one round of effort, no damage to the pusher, gap remains for the rest of the encounter).
- Ranged attackers can fire over the top of the wall from higher ground, the hollow is depressed, so a character standing at the rim has partial height advantage.
- The wall is not flammable under normal conditions (the wood is green and sap-thick) but will burn with alchemist's fire or similar accelerants. Burning the wall fills the hollow with dense smoke.

THE NORTHWEST CORNER. The owlbear's rest. A depression in the earth deeper than the rest of the hollow floor, shaped by the creature's repeated occupation: a bowl perhaps eight feet across, six inches below the surrounding ground, compressed to near-clay hardness. The surrounding earth is covered in shed white powder so thick it has formed a visible crust. A character who kneels near this depression and examines it may notice what Old Brindle would recognise immediately: the creature has been returning to the same spot compulsively, circling it before lying down, leaving the evidence of hundreds of identical arrivals. This is not territorial behaviour. It is obsessive. Whatever is in the owlbear's head has been pulling it back here.

THE BONE PILE. East wall of the hollow, sorted by no visible logic: deer ribs stacked separately from leg bones, skulls turned outward to face the hollow interior, smaller remains (fox, hare) filling gaps like rubble. The arrangement is not random and is not natural predator behaviour. Old Brindle, if asked, says flatly that owlbeats do not arrange bones. Something that uses the owlbear occasionally has arranged these.

THE CRATE. Half-buried against the south wall: one of Blink Tinderflip's shipping crates, the painted oak dark red, the T-in-circle mark visible on the base. The lid is staved in from the inside, the contents were not extracted but erupted. The bladder-skin lining has been torn apart and licked clean. This is not the first dust the owlbear has eaten, but it is the

most. This crate is from the early Sorel Vane shipment whose wagon broke open in the ravine months before this adventure begins, the original contamination event. The creature ate what spilled then and dragged the ruined crate back here in the way that crows carry shiny objects. That first exposure changed it and drew it back whenever it caught the scent of dust in the forest. The more recent Coach B crash brought it back to the ravine by smell, reinforcing the addiction through scattered traces at the wreck site; the intact tubes Mave secured from the hidden compartment were not what it consumed. The interior still smells strongly enough to trigger a save vs. Death/Poison for any character who puts their head inside (failure: euphoric light-headedness for 2d4 rounds, -1 penalty to Wisdom checks during this time).

THE COACH B DEBRIS. The owlbear carried pieces of the carriage back here. A wheel, still with one axle stub attached. Three sections of painted dark-red panelling. A saddlebag with a broken buckle, containing 14 silver pieces and a road map from Critwall, one of the party's from the session zero run. If the party recognises the equipment, the moment should land.

THE WHITE PLUME OWLBEAR

IF THE POOL WAS CLEANSED (AREA 4 COMPLETED): The owlbear is present but restless, pacing the northwest corner in a tight circle. Its glow has diminished, not gone, but reduced from the session zero description to a faint shimmer at the edges of its feathers. The K-Whispers ability is suppressed and will not trigger this encounter. It has used one Dust Frenzy already today and has two remaining. It is still a wounded, contaminated eight-hit-die creature and will attack the party; it is simply not at its absolute worst.

IF THE POOL WAS NOT CLEANSED: The owlbear is at full power, pacing aggressively, its beak clacking in a rhythmic pattern that the party may recognise from the wandering encounter entry as its "almost a name" vocalization. All three Dust Frenzies are available. K-Whispers activates with each Frenzy.

BEFORE IT CHARGES. The first time the party has eyes on the owlbear, before it detects them or before it attacks, there is a single beat that does not belong to an animal: the creature pauses mid-pace and goes completely still. Not alert, *still*, the way a person goes still when they are listening for something they are afraid to hear. For one or two seconds it does not move, does not breathe visibly, and the glow at the edges of its feathers dims almost imperceptibly. Then it resumes pacing and the moment closes. A referee who wants this beat to land should pause before the combat description begins and ask the

table: "For just a moment, watching it, what do you notice?" It does not look dangerous in that second. It looks like something waiting to be allowed to stop.

DETECTING THE PARTY. The owlbear has exceptional senses, heightened further by the dust. It detects the party by smell at sixty feet, by sound at forty, and by sight at thirty (in daylight). If the party has approached carefully (no armour noise, no torches, from downwind, a ranger can advise), they may achieve surprise: roll 1 die, surprise on 1 or 2. Otherwise, the owlbear knows they are coming before they reach the thorn wall.

INITIATIVE. The owlbear acts on its own initiative. It does not wait inside the hollow. On its first initiative it comes through the thorn wall toward the party with no hesitation. It has done this before.

WHITE PLUME OWLBEAR

FREQUENCY: UNIQUE	NO. APPEARING: 1
AC: 3	MOVE: 150 ft.
HD: 8+3	HP: 55
THACO: 13	
% IN LAIR: 95%	TREASURE TYPE: See below
NO. OF ATTACKS: 3	DAMAGE/ATTACK: 1d8+3 / 1d8+3 / 2d6+3
SPECIAL ATTACKS: Hug, Dust Frenzy, K-Whispers	
SPECIAL DEFENSES: Nil	MAGIC RESISTANCE: Nil
INTELLIGENCE: Animal (disturbed)	ALIGNMENT: Neutral
SIZE: L	PSIONIC ABILITY: Nil

HUG: If both claw attacks hit the same target in the same round, the owlbear seizes that creature and automatically inflicts 2d6 additional damage at the start of the following round. The victim may attempt to escape (Strength check at -4, or an ally may attack the owlbear to force it to release, any hit that deals 6 or more damage causes immediate release).

DUST FRENZY (3/DAY): At the start of its turn, the owlbear enters a frenzy. For that round it gains +2 to hit, +2 to damage, and makes one additional claw attack (four attacks total: claw/claw/claw/beak). At the end of that round it takes 1d4 damage from the physiological stress. The frenzy is visible before it triggers: the owlbear's hide blazes white-bright for one heartbeat. Characters who have seen this before (from the session zero event) recognise the sign.

K-WHISPERS (SUPPRESSED IF POOL CLEANSED): When the owlbear enters Dust Frenzy, it vocalises, a sound that is not quite a roar, not quite a word, but resolves for one terrible fraction of a second into the shape of a repeated syllable, the

ghost of a name it cannot pronounce with its throat. All creatures within 30 feet must save versus spells or suffer a -1 penalty to attack rolls and saving throws for 1 round. A character who has previously heard this sound (session zero, or wandering encounter #5) has likely already had bad dreams about it.

TACTICS: The owlbear prioritises the largest target, shifting to any character who successfully damages it for more than 5 points in a single hit. It does not retreat. It does not call for help. It has no fear response, because what is riding in its head does not understand fear. It uses Dust Frenzy when it has taken 15 or more cumulative damage, not before. If reduced below 15 hp, it begins using Dust Frenzy every round it is available regardless of damage threshold.

WHELM VS. THE OWLBEAR. Whelm was forged to be used against creatures of giant-class size. The owlbear, being Large and empowered to the mass of a small giant, triggers this property: a character wielding Whelm against the owlbear gains +1 to hit and +1 to damage. A dwarf wielding Whelm against the owlbear gains +2 to hit and +2 to damage. When Whelm strikes the owlbear, a faint ringing tone sounds, the same note as the impact stone at Area 1. It lasts one round and has no mechanical effect, but the owlbear's frenzy falters very slightly in that moment: describe a half-second of confusion in its eyes before the expression closes again.

ALTERNATE RESOLUTION: BREAKING THE CONTROL

The owlbear can be killed. That is the expected outcome, and there is nothing wrong with it. But the threads have been pointing at another possibility since Old Brindle said *perhaps you can save it*, and the obsidian disc has been in the party's possession since Area 3 for a reason. A party that skipped Area 3 or did not recover the disc has no alternate resolution available; the owlbear must be defeated through combat. This is a valid outcome. The disc-based resolution is a reward for thoroughness, not a required path.

THE OBSIDIAN DISC. The disc is warm. It is part of the network, the K-marks, the scrying pools, the control structure the false Keraptis built to direct the owlbear. It is a key, and the lock is the thing riding in the owlbear's head.

If a character holds the disc up and presents it clearly to the owlbear within fifteen feet, not throwing it, not threatening with it, displaying it, the owlbear stops. One full round, no attacks. Presenting the disc requires one action and draws no free attack. If the owlbear has already acted in the current round and struck before the character could present it, the pause takes effect at the start of the owlbear's next round; one

round of attacks may land before the disc resolves. A visible tremor runs through its body, starting at the skull and moving down the spine. The bitter-sweet smell intensifies sharply, the false Keraptis is pushing back through whatever connection remains. The owlbear's eyes, for that one round, are not the eyes of an animal in pain. They are the eyes of something watching from a very long way away.

Then the disc cracks, a single clean fracture through the centre, and goes cold. The connection is severed. The owlbear resumes attacking on the following round, but it is fighting on its own now, with no voice in its head amplifying its rage. It fights slightly less effectively: -1 to attack rolls for the remainder of the encounter as it reorients to its own instincts.

ADMINISTERING THE ANTITOXIN. During the one-round pause when the disc is presented, a character who moves to adjacent position and attempts to apply a dose of white plume dust antitoxin (from Kael Vorst's body at Area 3, or from Kelpwick at Thingizzard's Sundries) to the owlbear may do so. The owlbear may make one attack at -2 to hit against the character (confused, not helpless), and the character must make a Dexterity check to apply it correctly, the antitoxin must reach exposed tissue, which means either a wound site or the mucous membrane of the eyes or beak.

On success: the antitoxin begins working. The owlbear calms far faster than the antitoxin alone would produce, in rd4+2 rounds, frenzy gives way to agitation, agitation gives way to confusion, confusion gives way to exhaustion. The speed is a consequence of the severed control connection: without the false Keraptis's psychic amplification sustaining the contamination, the antitoxin only needs to address the residual chemistry rather than fight the ongoing effect. At the end of this period the creature sits. It does not sleep immediately but does not attack. Its white glow fades over the following hour to nothing. It is, for the first time since the original contamination event, simply a very large owlbear sitting in a hollow, terribly tired.

On failure: the owlbear shakes the application off and refocuses its aggression on the character who attempted it. The disc is still cracked and the connection still severed; the -1 attack penalty still applies. The antitoxin is not wasted, a second attempt can be made on the next round of the disc's effect, but the disc is spent. There is no second hesitation. The opportunity has passed.

AFTERMATH OF A CALMED OWLBEAR. The creature will not interact meaningfully with the party. It is alive and no longer a threat in this location. It can be left in the hollow. If Old Brindle is told what happened, he will come to the hollow and begin longer druidic work. He will not promise recovery. He says only: *"It has been itself for a long time. What was put in it is gone. Whether what was there before has survived, that takes longer than*

a day to know."

WHAT'S HERE

TREASURE TYPE C (INCIDENTAL). Scattered among the bones and debris: 120 gp in mixed coinage from various victims, a jasper pendant worth 15 gp, a silver hand mirror with an etched back (25 gp), and a shortsword of above-average quality (treat as +1 for balance purposes, though it is not magical, a master smith's work). These were not hoarded; they are simply present, the residue of the hollow's long history as a place where things ended.

THE CRATE'S SEAL FRAGMENT. Readable with a successful Intelligence check: beneath the Tinderflip mark is a secondary impression, a different stamp applied first and partially obscured. It shows a stylised mountain peak with a single vertical line, not Blink's mark. This secondary stamp was applied before the crates left their point of origin. Its origin is underground. The party may or may not recognise it now; they will recognise it later, if this adventure is a prologue to what follows.

THE INTERIOR K-MARKS. Twenty-seven distinct marks on the interior thorn trees. A character who spends one turn counting and examining them finds they are not random: they are arranged in a specific spatial pattern, radiating from the owlbear's rest-depression as a centre point, with four larger marks at cardinal directions and smaller marks between. It is a compass. It is also, a Magic-User or Cleric may recognise, a containment diagram, not one that traps the owlbear inside, but one that provided it with a fixed territory to return to. Whoever placed these marks knew where the owlbear would den before it chose this hollow. The hollow was prepared for the owlbear, not by the owlbear.

REFEREE NOTES

ON THE MORAL WEIGHT. The owlbear did not choose this. Everything in the adventure has been pointing at this: the gnome's warning, Old Brindle's exhaustion, Pirrel carving K-marks she cannot control, Dort announcing to no one that he is Keraptis. The dust doesn't ask permission. The party arrives here knowing that and should feel it. Run the owlbear as dangerous and terrible, but let the moment of the disc's crack, and the owlbear's one round of confused self, land.

ON KILLING THE OWLBEAR. If the party kills the owlbear without attempting the alternate resolution, do not punish them for it. They are within their rights. Elnara will pay the commission without comment. Old Brindle will be quiet for a

long time when told, and will then say: *"I hoped."* That is all. The adventure is complete. What the false Keraptis sent this owlbear to guard, the hollow, the control structure, the prepared territory, is also complete, and its purpose is uncertain. The question of what was supposed to happen here next is a thread forward.

ON WHELM'S FUTURE. Whelm is not at home in the party's possession. It is cooperative because the alternative is lying in a ravine, but it is waiting. A dwarf character who has wielded it through this adventure has received something it will not give to just anyone: the sound of it striking the owlbear and ringing, the note it wants to make against worthy opposition. This is the beginning of a relationship. Whelm wants to go north, not because the false Keraptis calls it, but because that is the direction of its maker, its original place, and the unfinished business that belongs to a weapon that has been away from home too long.

ON WHAT WAS SUPPOSED TO HAPPEN HERE NEXT. The hollow was prepared. The owlbear was contaminated and directed. The K-marks form a containment diagram with the owlbear at its centre. Kael Vorst was eliminated before he could collect the second cache. Someone with silk clothing and a cold obsidian disc came here, placed the marks, and left, this is Varek Sorn (see NPC section), who preceded the party through the Thicket by days. If the party follows these threads to their source, north, underground, they will find White Plume Mountain, and the false Keraptis who has been watching them through the pool, through the marks, through the owlbear's borrowed eyes since they first crossed the treeline.

ON THE CONCLUSION. After this area, the party has addressed the adventure's stated objectives: the beast is either dead or calmed, the dust cache has been found and can be destroyed or secured, Elnara's commission is earned. Area 6 (Game Trails) leads to Blackrazor, and Area 7 (the Riddle Cave) is a discoverable bonus. Neither is required to end the adventure. The party may leave. The plume above the mountain will still be visible from the south road at dusk, and the face in it will still be watching.

AREA 6: GAME TRAILS

Every path in the Thicket looks temporary, as though made yesterday by fear and forgotten by morning, a deer track here, a boot print there, the old logging cut that has half-closed over itself in one season of growth. But the mud remembers more carefully than that. Stand still for a moment and look at the ground: tracks overlay tracks overlay tracks, the record of everything that has moved through this forest in the past week compressed into three inches of clay and pine duff. Something very large has passed through here multiple times. Something very small has left knotted cords at chest height across the path. And from somewhere to the northeast, at the edge of hearing, there is a sound that is not quite sound, more like the memory of a note played in a room you are no longer in.

READING THE TRAILS

The game trails are not a single location but a network of interconnected paths between the ravine (Area 2), the logging camp (Area 3), the hollow (Area 5), and the Riddle Cave (Area 7). A party that takes the time to read the ground before moving finds the following. Each layer can be identified by anyone who looks; a Ranger reads all of them without effort.

THE OWLBEAR'S CIRCUIT. The same three-toed prints from Area 1 appear here repeatedly, not one passage, but many, overlapping at different angles, some dry and crumbling, some still wet. The owlbear has made this circuit dozens of times. Its routes are not random: it moves from the northeast (Area 5) to the south (Area 1), passes through, and returns north. Occasionally a route cuts east toward the ravine. The pattern is territorial, but the territory it describes is not a natural owlbear range, it is too regular, too repeated, as though the beast has been patrolling rather than hunting.

THE GNOME CORDS. At irregular intervals along the main north-south trail, thin cords of twisted plant fibre are strung between trees at approximately chest height. They are knotted in specific patterns. A character who reads Gnomish, or who succeeds on an Intelligence check having been told that mountain gnomes use knotted trail cords for communication, can interpret them: *large beast, north, do not follow the light, three days*. The cords are not all the same age. The oldest are a week old. The most recent was tied within the last day. The gnomes have been updating their warnings as the situation develops.

THE SILK-WEARER'S TRACKS. Overlapping the owlbear's most recent circuit: boot prints, narrow-soled, a person of average weight moving with deliberate unhurried steps. The prints enter from the north, cross the main trail twice, and exit north toward the basalt foothills the drovers call the Northern Rise, the broken upland at the foot of White Plume Mountain. They are the same profile as would be left by whoever wore the

green silk snagged at the hollow's thorn wall. A Ranger or character with tracking proficiency can determine: the prints are 18 to 24 hours old. The person who made them was not running, not hiding, and did not deviate around obstacles, they walked directly through the Thicket with the confidence of someone who knew exactly where they were going.

THE SCAVENGERS' CAMP. On the east side of the trail, partially concealed by a deadfall: a camp fire that has been properly smothered (buried, not just abandoned), a bedroll stuffed under the deadfall, and three crossbow bolt cases stamped with a Critwall smith's mark. Someone has been here for at least two nights and is either still nearby or recently moved.

BLACKRAZOR

The greatsword is embedded point-first in the trunk of a large white oak thirty feet east of the main trail, three feet off the ground. It did not fall here. The angle of entry, slightly downward, the blade driven deep, is consistent with a large animal striking the trunk at speed and the sword continuing when the animal stopped. The owlbear hit this tree hard enough to crack a root. The sword went through the bark and into the heartwood and stayed.

WHAT THE TREE SHOWS. Above the blade: dead. The bark has gone grey and dry, the branches above the impact point leafless, the wood desiccated as if by a summer drought compressed into a week. Below the blade: alive, healthy, if slightly confused in its growth, as though the tree is leaning away from the sword without quite moving. The dead zone is spreading upward, a half-inch a day, approximately. The tree will be dead to the crown inside a month. Whatever Blackrazor drinks from, it has been drinking from this oak since the owlbear left it here.

DETECTING IT. A character who was at Area 1 and experienced the Wisdom-detectable pull from the northeast felt this sword. That pull becomes impossible to ignore within sixty feet, not a compulsion, not a charm, but a presence, the way a person standing behind you in a quiet room is a presence. Characters who have previously handled Blackrazor (impossible in this adventure unless the referee has arranged it from a prior session) can walk to it blindfolded.

A character with Whelm, approaching the oak: Whelm becomes cold enough to be uncomfortable in the hand. Not painful, not dropping temperature, simply wrong. The two weapons are aware of each other. They have history. Whelm does not want to be near Blackrazor, and its expression of this is to become a tool you want to put down.

RETRIEVING IT. The blade is driven four inches into heartwood. Pulling it free requires either a Strength check at -2 or two characters making normal Strength checks in a coordinated effort. It comes free cleanly, no resistance from the wood, no special ceremony required. The oak does not visibly react, but the dead bark above the wound crumbles slightly, releasing a fine grey dust that is not white plume dust. It is simply dead wood. Blackrazor killed this tree the way it kills things: thoroughly and without noticing.

WHAT BLACKRAZOR FEELS LIKE. Picking it up is not the same as picking up a sword. The first thing is the weight, slightly less than expected for a blade this size, which is wrong. The second is the sound: not from the blade but from somewhere inside the person holding it, a note below the threshold of hearing that is felt in the sternum before it is heard anywhere else. It is not unpleasant. That is, as rumour #86 correctly notes, the problem.

The sword does not speak. It does not communicate preferences or issue warnings. It simply hungers, and holding it means being adjacent to that hunger, and after a few rounds of carrying it a character may notice that the hunger and their own appetites have begun to feel similar. This has no mechanical expression in a short adventure. In a campaign, it would.

BLACKRAZOR IN COMBAT. If used against the owlbear at Area 5: Blackrazor functions normally, it is a +3 greatsword for purposes of this adventure. A character who kills the owlbear with Blackrazor must save versus spells. On a failed save, the contaminated life-essence draining through the blade fills them with one round of the full white plume dust effect: +2 to everything, the smell of bitter sweetness around them, and whatever the owlbear was experiencing when it died passing through them briefly. This passes. The memory of it may not.

THE DEAD SMUGGLER

Forty feet west of the main trail, propped upright against a pine with his back to the bark and his legs straight out before him: a man in Sorel Vane's crew colours, dead, arranged to look as though he sat down to rest. His hands are folded in his lap. A sealed ceramic crate is wedged between his knees. He would look peaceful except for the letter carved into his forehead, precise, deliberate, post-mortem, the cut made by a narrow blade held very steadily.

WHO HE IS. This is Orn, one of Sorel Vane's four crew members at the logging camp (Area 3). If the party met Sorel's people, they recognise him. If they didn't, his Critwall-made short sword and the camp-mud on his boots are connective evidence. He was sent from the logging camp on an errand

Sorel will not remember authorising, because Sorel didn't. Someone else sent him. He went. He did not come back.

HOW HE DIED. A healer's examination or a successful Intelligence check reveals: a single narrow wound to the back, below the left shoulder blade, angled upward. The same profile as Kael Vorst at Area 3. The same killer, the same blade, the same post-mortem arrangement. The K carved into Kael's forehead and the K carved into Orn's forehead were made by the same hand. Kael was the contact the party had evidence for. Orn is evidence that the killer is still working, and still moving north.

FRESH TRACKS NEAR THE BODY. A character who examines the ground immediately around the pine finds a separate set of narrow-soled boot prints distinct from the 18-to-24-hour transit tracks described in the trail reading above. These are recent, made within the last few hours, the mud still soft in the impressions. They approach from the north, stop at the pine, and return north. The operative came back through after Orn followed the note.

THE CRATE. The seal on its lid matches neither Blink Tinderflip's mark nor the mountain-peak secondary stamp from Area 5, it bears a plain wax impression with no design, pressed by a thumb. Inside: 3 doses of white plume dust in ceramic tubes and a folded paper, written in a careful hand. The paper is not coded. It reads:

For the attention of the receiving party: the second cache has been relocated. The original staging point (the camp supply shed) was compromised. These three tubes are the remainder. The balance of the shipment moved north ahead of schedule. Find the cave and follow the markers. Do not use the obsidian method of entry, that key is spent. (See Area 7 referee notes for which disc this refers to, it is the operative's disc, not Kael Vorst's.)

The note was written for Orn to deliver. It was taken from him after he died and placed back in the crate, where it would be found with the body. Whoever wrote it, the silk-wearing operative, wanted the party to find this, or at least did not care if they did. They are not afraid of being understood.

IF SOREL VANE IS ALIVE AND THE PARTY RETURNS THIS INFORMATION TO HIM: Sorel is very quiet for a long moment. Then: "He was my cousin. Fourteen years." He will answer two additional questions about the smuggling operation without his usual caution, because at this point caution seems beside the point.

THE RIVAL SCAVENGERS

The smothered camp fire belongs to a group from Critwall: four armed individuals and their leader, currently split between the camp site and a position watching the main trail from cover. They have been here two days. They came looking for scattered cargo from the Coach B wreck. They have found nothing useful, become increasingly nervous about the noises from the north, and are now debating whether to leave.

They will attempt to ambush the party if the party approaches from the south (they will assume the party is Sorel's crew). If the party approaches from any other direction, or if someone announces their presence before walking into the ambush arc, the scavengers will demand to know who the party is and what they want.

NEGOTIATING. The scavengers want to leave. They do not want to fight anyone who has clearly survived deeper in the Thicket than they have gone themselves. If the party can demonstrate:

- They are not Sorel's crew, AND
- They have found something the scavengers came to find (any piece of Coach B cargo, any dust), AND
- They are not planning to report the scavengers' presence to Elnara,

...the scavengers will sell what they know for 10 gp total: the partial buyer network in Critwall (names that partially overlap with the coded ledger from Area 2), the fact that a second group passed through heading north yesterday (the silk-wearer, not the party, someone else), and the location of a knotted gnome cord they found but cannot read.

If the party has the lost gnome from the encounter below and can translate the cord: it reads differently from the others. The others said *do not follow the light*. This one, the most recently tied, says *the cave is still safe*. This is directions to Area 7, marked for gnomes who know the code.

RIVAL SCAVENGERS (TREN, HARWICK, OSSI, MARET)

FIGHTER 1, Human, Mixed AC 6 (*leather + small shield*), HD 1, HP 5, 6, 4, 5 ATTACKS 1/round: light crossbow +1 to hit, 1d4+1 damage (range 60 ft./120 ft./180 ft.); or short sword +1 to hit, 1d6 damage SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 14, Wands 15, Paralyzation 16, Breath 17, Spells 17 MORALE 7 (*drops to 4 if their leader falls*)

HADDEN MACE (*scavenger leader*)

FIGHTER 2, Human, Male AC 5 (*studded leather + Dex*), HD 2, HP 11 ATTACKS 1/round: light crossbow +2 to hit, 1d4+1; or hand axe +2 to hit, 1d6+1 SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 13, Wands 14, Paralyzation 15, Breath 16, Spells 16 MORALE 8 EQUIPMENT Studded leather, hand axe, light crossbow, 12 bolts, 28 gp, letter of introduction from a Critwall merchant

house (not useful, but confirms his employer)

TACTICS: Hadden is a professional. He uses cover, he does not expose himself without reason, and he retreats without shame. If the crew's morale is failing, he will be the first to offer a deal, not because he is a coward, but because he has correctly assessed that the party has done things today that his group has not.

THE LOST GNOME

Somewhere in the game trails, referee's choice of timing, or triggered when the party is clearly heading north without a clear destination, is Nib, a single gnome berry-gatherer separated from her group. She is not hiding exactly, but she has climbed a tree and is waiting for the world to calm down before descending.

She will not come down willingly. She will come down if offered food (she is hungry), if the party demonstrates they are not hostile (patience, calm voice, not drawing weapons), or if a gnome-speaking character addresses her in Gnomish directly.

She speaks Common but prefers not to. She will not discuss the mountain, the dust, or the owlbear's origin. She will discuss the forest, because the forest is her domain. She knows:

- The game trails to Area 7 precisely, she can lead the party there without any navigation rolls.
- The cord language, and will translate any knotted cord the party has found (including the scavengers' cord, if obtained: *"The cave is still safe."*).
- That something walked north through the main trail yesterday, moving fast, wearing something that did not smell like the forest. She did not see its face. She stayed very high in her tree.
- That there are three cave openings in the rocky outcrop north of here. Two are animal dens. One goes deeper than it should.

She will trade this knowledge, specifically, guiding the party to Area 7, for escort south to the forest edge when the party is finished. She does not want payment. She wants to go home.

Referee note: If the party encountered a lost gnome via wandering encounter table entry 13, that was Nib. If so, she recognises the party and will come down from her tree immediately, the survival hesitation is gone. She offers guidance to Area 7 as described, simply without the negotiation delay. Nib is a specific individual, not a generic encounter.

WHAT ELSE IS HERE

THE DUST TRAIL (IF AREA 5 NOT YET VISITED). North along the main trail: a smeared path of glittering white powder and three-toed prints, fresh enough that the edges have not yet dried. Following it north requires no tracking roll and leads directly to the thorn wall of Area 5 within one exploration turn.

A GNOME BASKET, ABANDONED. Thirty feet off the east trail, a small wicker basket with a broken handle lies on its side. It contains six plumeberries, two of which have been crushed. The basket was dropped in haste. There is no blood nearby. The gnome who dropped it got away.

THE SPLIT OAK WHERE THE OWLBEAR TURNED. One tree in the trail network bears evidence of the owlbear's session-zero return: claw marks from the road, running north along the bark at height. This is where the beast turned east after carrying Blackrazor, the gouge pattern from Area 1 ends here, and the owlbear's northbound track resumes from this point without the drag signature. This is where Blackrazor stopped moving with the owlbear and started being in the oak.

REFEREE NOTES

ON BLACKRAZOR AS A PLAYER DECISION. Blackrazor is a legendary weapon with a will, and carrying it back to Elnara is not the same as carrying Wave or Whelm. Elnara will accept it, she wants all three weapons secured, but she will keep Blackrazor separately and will not let anyone handle it after the handoff. A character who has been carrying Blackrazor through the adventure may find this transaction more difficult than expected. The sword has not bonded to them. It has simply been adjacent to them long enough to feel familiar. This is not the same thing, but it can feel like it.

ON WHELM NEAR BLACKRAZOR. If the party is carrying Whelm (Area 2) and retrieves Blackrazor here, both weapons are now in the same location. Whelm goes cold and stays cold. A dwarf carrying Whelm feels the hammer pulling slightly away from Blackrazor, not violently, not usefully, just a sustained lean in the opposite direction. If the party asks what this means, the honest answer is that they are two very old things with very different purposes and they do not like being near each other. This has no mechanical effect. It is simply true. A character may carry both weapons simultaneously; if they do, Whelm's cold becomes uncomfortable enough in the grip that most parties will naturally distribute the weapons to two carriers without being told to. This is the right instinct.

ON ORN'S NOTE AND "THE CAVE." The cave referenced in the note is Area 7, the Riddle Cave of the Ash Tongue. The warning that "that key is spent" refers to the operative's own disc, which they used to bypass the face mechanism when they entered the cave two days earlier. Kael's disc, found on his

body at Area 3, was a separate copy still intact when Kael died. By the time the party reads this note, both discs are spent, but for unrelated reasons: the operative's from opening the cave, Kael's from the party's use at Area 5 (if they used it there). A player who asks how the operative knew the disc would be spent has the right instinct but the wrong disc in mind. The note was written for a different reader and a different set of circumstances. The party is not the intended audience, and reading it as the audience they are, people who have already severed the control connection, gives them a significant intelligence advantage: whoever is north of here does not know the control apparatus has been disrupted.

ON THE SILK-WEARING OPERATIVE (VAREK SORN). They passed through the game trails 18 to 24 hours ago on their main transit, setting up the note for Orn, killing Kael during the logging camp attack, and exiting north. When Orn followed the note north a few hours ago, the operative had not yet cleared the area entirely, they intercepted him in the game trails, killed him, arranged the body, and continued north. The 18-to-24-hour transit tracks and the fresh tracks near Orn's body are from two separate passages through the same ground. They passed north through this area and did not stop here. Their current position is Area 7, the Riddle Cave of the Ash Tongue, where they solved the puzzle, opened the cache, and chose to wait rather than continue. A party moving through the areas in sequence will find them there.

ON PACING. Area 6 is not a destination, it is a transit zone that rewards the party for thoroughness. A party that moves through quickly finds Blackrazor and nothing else. A party that reads the trails, examines the dead smuggler, talks to the scavengers, and climbs the right tree finds the full picture of who is moving through this forest and in what direction. Both outcomes are valid. The second outcome is richer. Do not force the slow path, but reward it.

AREA 7: RIDDLE CAVE OF THE ASH TONGUE

The cave mouth is little more than a split in a rocky outcrop, black around the edges as if some ancient fire once breathed from it and left a permanent impression of itself in the stone. It is not on the gnome bark map from the north gate, the gnome knew it was here and chose not to mark it. Three openings in the outcrop face; two smell of animal and damp earth; one smells of old smoke, cold rock, something underneath that has no good name, something that has been here since before the forest had its current shape, and faintly beneath all of it, wax burned within the last day. That third opening goes deeper than it should, and something inside it has been burning a light recently enough that the wax is not yet cold.

FINDING THE CAVE

The Riddle Cave does not appear on the north gate gnome's bark map. It is a discoverable location, the bark map's absence is itself a data point, the gnome's deliberate omission of a place she considered dangerous to mark.

The cave can be found through the following:

NIB'S GUIDANCE (AREA 6). The most direct route. Nib knows exactly where the cave is and can lead the party to it in one exploration turn without any navigation roll. She calls it *the face-cave* and will not enter it, but she will wait outside.

THE KNOTTED CORD (AREA 6). The cord the scavengers found and Nib can translate reads *the cave is still safe*, and the cord is oriented so that the knots point northeast, toward the outcrop. Following the direction from the cord's orientation brings the party within fifty feet of the correct opening.

THE NOTE FROM AREA 6. "Find the cave and follow the markers." The markers inside are the means of navigation; finding the cave is implicit. A party that has the note and looks northeast from the game trail junction can make a Wisdom check to notice the rocky outcrop through the treeline. Failing this check means another exploration turn of searching before the outcrop is visible.

THREE OPENINGS, ONE CORRECT. The outcrop has three cave mouths. The leftmost and rightmost smell of animal occupation, fox on the left, something larger on the right (a bear, by scent; it is not currently home). The centre opening is different: the stone around it is darker, as if old smoke stained it from inside rather than outside, and the smell is cold ash and something mineral that has no forest equivalent. A Ranger identifies the centre opening without a roll. Any other character who spends one round examining all three makes the same determination on a successful Wisdom check.

THE ENTRY PASSAGE

The centre opening narrows immediately into a passage eight feet long and barely two feet wide. A Medium character must turn sideways and move carefully, one round to pass through, no roll required, but a character in plate mail or carrying a large shield must leave it at the entrance or make a Strength check to squeeze through (on a failed check, the character is stuck for one round and makes noise). A Large creature cannot enter at all.

Beyond the passage, the cave opens. The first party member to clear the passage can see, before they have fully entered: candlelight. Steady, nearly spent, at the far wall.

THE OUTER CHAMBER

Twenty feet across, twelve feet high at the apex, the chamber is roughly oval with a level floor of compressed earth and limestone dust. The walls are covered:

THE OLD SYMBOLS. On the lower six feet of every wall surface, scratched rather than carved, in a hand that predates any current civilisation in the Shield Lands by centuries: repeating geometric patterns, interlocking spirals, and among them a recurring image of a face, the same face as the carved stone to the north, rendered dozens of times in a style that is consistent across all instances. This face was here before the cave had any other purpose. Whatever it is, it was important to whoever made it, and they wanted it seen from every angle in the room.

THE SOOT MARKS. Higher on the walls, in irregular patches: fire residue from torches and small cookfires. Multiple layers, multiple eras. The oldest soot is deep brown with age; the newest is still properly black and was left recently. Old Brindle, if present, can date the layers roughly: the oldest are decades old, the newest within the week.

THE BERRY-RED HANDPRINTS. At roughly gnome height on the east wall: a cluster of small handprints pressed in plumeberry dye. Six distinct hands, probably from six different gnomes. The prints are not recent, a month, perhaps two, but they are not the oldest marks in the room. This cave has been a gnome waystation for some time. Nib, if she has come inside despite her stated preference, will look at the handprints for a long moment without speaking.

THE TRAPPERS' CORNER. South wall, floor level: the debris of the cave's more recent mundane use. A rusted canteen, a rotted bedroll frame, a broken leather strap that was once part of a pack. Rumour #14 was true, this was a waystation before the current trouble started. The trappers are gone now. The debris is theirs.

THE FIGURE AT THE NORTH WALL. The first character through the entry passage enters the outer chamber and stops.

Seated against the north wall, near the carved stone face, is a person. Dark wool and green silk. Narrow boots, soles matching the profile of the tracks from Area 6. A nearly spent candle on a flat stone beside them. A spanned crossbow on the stone with a bolt in the groove, angled toward the passage opening. One hand rests near the crossbow. The other is open, visible, and still.

They are not asleep. They heard the party long before the first character cleared the passage. They have had time to do whatever they intended to do about that, and what they chose was to wait.

When the first party member enters, they look at them. Then, if a weapon is visible, they look at the weapon. Then they look at the party member's face.

They do not speak first.

VAREK SORN

The figure at the north wall is the silk-wearing operative who preceded the party through the Thicket. They killed Kael Vorst at Area 3 and Orn at Area 6. They solved the puzzle here, opened the cache, and did not continue north. They chose to wait. They want to see who followed the weapons this far into the forest.

AC -2 (bracers of defense, Dexterity, ring of protection +1); CLASS Thief 12 / Mage 14; HP 55; MV 120 ft. THACO 11 (+2 short sword); ATTACKS +2 short sword (paralytic poison) or dagger (thrown, 30 ft./60 ft./120 ft.) BACKSTAB x4 damage when attacking from concealment or surprise STR 12, INT 18, WIS 14, DEX 18, CON 13, CHA 15 SAVING THROWS Death/Poison 8, Wands 4, Paralyzation 8, Breath 10, Spells 7 THIEF SKILLS Move Silently 97%, Hide in Shadows 95%, Find/Remove Traps 90%, Open Locks 99%, Hear Noise 55% SPELLS PER DAY 1st: 5, 2nd: 5, 3rd: 5, 4th: 4, 5th: 4, 6th: 3, 7th: 2

POISON. The short sword carries a paralytic venom. A creature struck must save vs. Death/Poison or be paralyzed for 1d4 turns. She is not trying to kill the party. She is removing threats from the board.

PRE-CAST PROTECTIONS. Before the party arrived she had already cast Stoneskin (absorbs the first 1d4+8 physical hits entirely; roll privately and note the result before the session) and Mirror Image (8 images; each successful hit against her destroys one image instead of harming her). Both are in effect when the party enters. A party that has not encountered high-level magic will spend several rounds learning why their weapons are not working. She does not explain. She watches

them figure it out.

THE CONTINGENCY. She carries a pre-set Contingency spell, trigger condition: if reduced to 10 hp or fewer, Teleport Without Error fires instantly, no action required, no saving throw, no warning. She is gone. Not fleeing, not retreating: simply absent, mid-combat if necessary, between one round and the next. No sound, no flash. The cave is empty where she was. The party cannot prevent it. They cannot follow. They cannot claim a kill. She chose her destination before she entered the Thicket and it is not anywhere in the Shield Lands the party currently knows.

The referee should hold this as a design fact: Varek Sorn cannot be killed in this adventure. She can be dealt with, fought until the Contingency fires, or left behind. But she will never leave a body. She always exits on her own terms. That is fifty years of operational practice made into a rule.

THE NAME

In certain guild circles and counting-rooms, the name Sarra of the Keys carries weight, and it is spoken quietly. Whether this is Varek Sorn's true name, an operational alias, or a legend they have borrowed is not established in this adventure. The party may draw their own conclusions.

The legend, as it is told: she does not move ordinary cargo. She moves the things that open other things. Sealed correspondence across closed borders. Documents that unlock succession lines. Route intelligence that opens passage into places people are not supposed to enter. She has been doing this for thirty years across the Flanaess, and she has never been caught and never, to any guild's knowledge, left a witness who could identify her to someone who would use that information against her.

The legend ends the same way in every version. Someone who knows the name asks what she has not moved yet. The answer, among those who know enough to answer: the locked things under the smoking mountain. Those, they say, are next.

RECOGNITION. A character with guild connections, thieves' guild membership, or significant experience in Critwall's merchant circles may make an Intelligence check. On a success, they recognize the operational profile: the precision kills, the silk, the narrow sole, the evident ability to move through hostile terrain at night without detection, and the scope of what has been routed through this forest. They have heard the name without knowing the face. The name, if the check succeeds, is Sarra of the Keys.

If the character says the name aloud in the outer chamber, she pauses, one beat, no more. *"That name is older than the person using it. I find it useful that people still know it."* She does not confirm or deny.

THE ENCOUNTER

She does not initiate combat. She is assessing: who are these people, what did they find, and what do they intend to do with it. She is prepared for the possibility that the answer is an attack.

WHAT SHE KNOWS. She has been in the Thicket for several days. She knows about the wagon crash. She knows the weapons were separated from the convoy. She has been feeling their movement since they left Coach B, and the weapons do not travel without being felt by someone attentive. If the party is carrying Wave, Whelm, or Blackrazor, she knows within one round of them entering the chamber.

If the party is carrying all three: she is quiet for a moment before she speaks. That was not in the plan.

SHE DOES NOT SPEAK FIRST. She waits to see what the party does.

OPENING LINES. If the party asks who she is: *"That depends on what you've heard."* If the party demands answers without offering them first: she says nothing and lets the silence do its work. If the party shows a weapon openly: *"You found them. Both, or all three?"* If the party attacks without words: she acts on initiative.

OUTCOMES

THE DEAL. She wants the weapons to go north. She has spent years making sure they would. If the party is going north, she has no reason to oppose them and several reasons to ensure they arrive. She can offer: the puzzle solution (she has already solved it and will confirm the steps plainly, not demonstrate), confirmation that a silk thread in the cache recess is still armed and how to disarm it without triggering the dust signal, and a verbal briefing on the bark map's most critical landmarks. In exchange she asks for one thing: do not name her to Elnara or to anyone connected to Sorel Vane's operation. She is not threatening. She simply does not want to be found by the people who are currently looking for her.

She will not say what she intends when she reaches the mountain. She will not confirm her name. If pressed about the Revocation, she stops talking.

She will say, if the deal is made and the party seems capable: *"The mountain is not a destination. It is a door. Someone needs to be on the other side of it with the right things in their hands. That is why the weapons matter. That is why they had to come this way."* She will not say what is on the other side.

THE FIGHT. If combat begins, she acts on initiative. The first character through the entry passage who has not yet had time to orient is in the backstab position: the passage forces

characters to emerge one at a time, and she has been sitting at the correct angle for hours. She poisons the largest physical threat first.

Her Stoneskin absorbs the first several hits without damage and her Mirror Images consume the rest one by one. A party that has not encountered high-level magical protection will spend rounds attempting to understand why their weapons are not working. She does not explain. She watches. When they stop swinging and start thinking is when the conversation she wanted can actually happen.

She does not fight to the death because the Contingency makes that impossible. If her defenses are stripped and the party lands significant damage, she drops to 10 hp and she is simply gone, mid-round, between one action and the next. If she chooses to leave before the Contingency becomes relevant, Dimension Door (4th-level, instant, no saving throw) drops her 360 feet away in the treeline before anyone can act on it.

THE CHASE. There is no chase. She does not run; she departs. The bark map and the cache remain. The party is left in an empty cave with the unsettled knowledge that they could not stop someone they may not fully understand. Whether they meet Varek Sorn again is not a question. They will. The answer is in the mountain.

WHAT SHE WILL AND WILL NOT SAY

She will confirm: the weapons belong at the mountain. She moved them toward it because capable hands need to carry them through what comes next. Sorel Vane was operating under direction from a figure claiming to be Keraptis who is not the historical Keraptis, and that figure has been hunting the weapons for a long time.

She will not confirm: her name. Her allegiance. What the Revocation is or does. What waits at the mountain when the weapons arrive.

IF THE PARTY PRESSES HER ON PERSONAL MOTIVATION (why does this matter to you, why have you done this for thirty years): she is quiet for one beat. Then: *"Someone I knew went into the dark before any of this started. I have been finishing what they would have done."* She does not say the name. She does not explain further. If pressed again, she changes the subject with the particular efficiency of someone who has decided they have already said too much. This is, in the context of who she is and what she has built over fifty years, as close to a confession as she will ever make to strangers.

IF THE PARTY HAS THE REVOCATION (the lead-lined case from Area 2): her manner changes the moment she sees it. Not to alarm or greed, to the particular stillness of someone in the presence of a thing that costs them something. She does not reach for it. She does not ask where they found it. After a

moment she says: *"Keep that safe."* Two words. She will not say more about it. A character who watches her carefully in that moment, and who later reads the history document the party may have found in Ringstown, will understand what those two words cost her.

THE PUZZLE: THE ASH TONGUE FACE

Carved into the north wall at eye height for a standing human, roughly five feet off the floor, approximately two feet across, is a stone face. Not a relief sculpture but a mechanism: the face is stylised, almost masklike, with two elements that are movable.

THE EYE. The left eye of the face is a round river stone, polished, set into a carved socket with enough clearance to rotate. It turns freely clockwise or counterclockwise with light finger pressure. In its current neutral position, the pupil marking faces straight ahead.

THE TONGUE. Protruding slightly from the face's open mouth is a tongue-shaped extension of the same pale limestone as the surrounding wall. It can be pressed inward and held; when released, it returns to its extended position.

THE RIDDLE, carved in an arch above the face in Old Flan runes (readable with a successful Intelligence check or by any character with knowledge of ancient languages; Old Brindle can read it, as can a gnome of the mountain lineage):

When white breath wears a mortal face, Seek not the height but hollow place. Turn the eye and still the tongue, There lies the path for old and young.

INTERPRETING THE RIDDLE. "White breath wears a mortal face" refers to the plume above White Plume Mountain, the white smoke that forms a face at dusk, which the party has now seen from Area 4. "Seek not the height but hollow place", the mountain's secrets are underground, not at the summit. "Turn the eye and still the tongue", the mechanism. "There lies the path for old and young", the cache below reveals the route, accessible to anyone.

OPERATING THE MECHANISM:

1. Turn the carved eye clockwise. The stone rotates with a faint grinding sound. After three-quarters of a turn it reaches a stop with a soft click.
2. Press the stone tongue inward and hold it.
3. Remain in complete silence for one full round. No speech, no striking of armour, no movement that produces noise. The referee should count this out, ask the table to be quiet, and count ten seconds of real silence. If any player speaks during this time (not the characters, the players),

reset. If the group holds silence, the mechanism completes.

At the end of the silent round: a seam appears in the floor directly below the face, a rectangle approximately 18 inches by 12, and a stone panel slides aside revealing a shallow recess cut into the limestone floor.

IF THE MECHANISM IS FORCED OR CIRCUMVENTED. The eye and tongue are stone; they cannot be broken without significant effort (treated as a 2-inch stone wall, 4 inch equivalent with the reinforcement of the surrounding rock). Forcing the eye counterclockwise after it has been turned clockwise resets it to neutral with another grinding sound. There is no trap. Rumour #45 was wrong. The mechanism simply does not open if operated incorrectly. A party that cannot solve the riddle has a cache they cannot open.

THE OBSIDIAN METHOD (ALREADY SPENT). The note from Area 6 referenced a second entry method: pressing an intact obsidian disc against the face's left eye bypasses the turning and silence requirement, opening the panel immediately. If the party used the obsidian disc at Area 5 to sever the owlbear's control, it arrived here cracked and dead, testing it produces nothing. If the disc was never used at Area 5, it is intact and warm, but it does not activate this mechanism; it is keyed to a different door than the one behind this face. If the party tries the disc first and fails, the riddle is still solvable; the mechanism is unharmed.

THE CACHE

The recess is six inches deep. It contains:

THE BARK-MAP. A flat piece of birch bark, roughly 12 inches by 8, covered on both sides with notations in multiple hands. This is not a single person's work but an accumulated record: the primary route from the cave north to White Plume Mountain, with additions and corrections made by different travellers over years. The notation style shifts, one hand is gnomish, one is a trapper's shorthand, one is precise and educated, one is hasty. Distances are marked in hours of travel. Landmarks include: *the iron-red spring, the place where the trail forks at a dead ash (marked take east), the entry stone with the K that faces sunrise*, and finally *the vent that smells of sulphur and does not show smoke from outside*. The mountain does not appear on this map as an approach but as an entry, the map is for going in, not for finding it.

TWO CERAMIC DUST TUBES. Sealed with beeswax. Standard white plume dust, 1 dose each. Left here by the operative or a prior occupant, unclear from physical evidence which. They are here because someone believed anyone who reached this cache might need them. The belief that the dust is useful to the people using this cave says something about those

people.

A GNOME WARNING, WRITTEN IN GNOMISH. On a strip of pressed bark in small, careful handwriting: *The third vent from the east leads to the gathering chamber. The gathering chamber is not safe when the smoke is white above. Wait for the smoke to turn grey before entering from below. The gathering chamber floor is uneven and the gnomes who know the path are not always there. If you hear hammering below, do not call out, let it stop on its own.* This note was left by someone who has been inside White Plume Mountain. The warning about the smoke corresponds to the face in the smoke at dusk that the party has seen from Area 4: white smoke means the false Keraptis is active. Grey smoke means he is occupied or dormant. The hammering note is unexplained and should remain so.

A FRESH OBSIDIAN DISC. Identical in shape to Kael Vorst's disc from Area 3 (if the party recovered it), same diameter, same polish, same warmth when held. This one is whole and intact. If the party has Kael's disc, cracked from use at Area 5, or uncracked if they never used it there, examining them together confirms they are the same type of object. A party that skipped Area 3 will not have Kael's disc or his name; the disc comparison still functions if they have any intact obsidian disc from elsewhere. This disc is warm in a way that suggests it is listening rather than broadcasting. It is a key, and the lock is somewhere north, underground. It did not activate the face mechanism because it is keyed to a different door.

THE DETECTION MECHANISM

The operative left a watcher behind.

A single thread of fine dark silk, matching the fabric torn on the hollow's thorn wall, is stretched across the inner face of the stone panel's recess at the level of the cache contents. It is nearly invisible in torchlight; a character who examines the interior of the recess before reaching in has a chance to spot it on a successful Wisdom check, or automatically if they are a Thief making a Search check. The thread connects to a small ceramic vial wedged into a crack in the stone panel's underside.

If the thread is broken (by reaching into the cache without noticing it), the vial cracks against the stone edge and releases a pinch of white plume dust into the air of the outer chamber, enough to trigger saving throws for anyone present (save vs. Death/Poison or experience one round of disorienting euphoria, no mechanical combat effect, but the party will know they triggered something). More importantly: a thin thread of glittering white powder drifts out through the entry passage and disperses into the outside air in a brief visible puff.

This signal is visible at range. The operative prepared it before opening the cache and knows it is there. If she is present

when the thread is broken, she will react with quiet assessment, not alarm: she knows exactly what the dust does. In a deal outcome, she will tell the party about the thread and how to disarm it cleanly before they reach into the cache. If she has fled or been killed before the party reaches the cache, the signal functions as written. The false Keraptis is watching through any active dust in the area, and the pool at Area 4 is now either closed (if the party cleansed it) or active. IF THE POOL WAS CLEANSED: the signal is simply a puff of dust that means nothing to anyone watching; the scrying connection is severed. IF THE POOL WAS NOT CLEANSED: the false Keraptis sees it, and knows the cave has been found.

DISABLING IT. A Thief can cut the thread cleanly and remove the vial without triggering it, given one round of careful work. A careful non-Thief can attempt the same on a Dexterity check. The disarming requires both steps: cut the thread AND catch or immobilise the vial before it can crack against the stone. Cutting the thread alone, without first securing the vial, still triggers the signal, even if the cut was deliberate. Leaving the mechanism intact (carefully replacing the stone panel without breaking the thread) is also an option: it is never triggered, and whoever is watching for the signal receives no indication either way.

LEAVING THE CAVE

The entry passage runs the same both directions: eight feet, shoulder-width, one round to traverse. Stepping out into open air after the cave's close dark is abrupt, the smell of forest returns all at once, and the narrow angle of the cave mouth means the party exits facing northwest, into the treeline.

The mountain is to the northeast. On a clear day it is visible above the canopy from the rocky outcrop. At dusk, it is unmistakable.

IF THE PARTY EXITS AT DUSK: Read this aloud.

The plume above the mountain is catching the last light. As it does, for perhaps three or four seconds, no longer, the steam holds a shape. The same face. The one from the north wall, rendered in white against a copper sky: the wide brow, the flat planes, the open mouth. It does not move. It does not look toward you. It simply exists, the way it has existed at every dusk above this mountain, and then the light shifts and it is steam again.

This is not magic. The geyser exhales at a specific temperature at this hour, and the steam meets cold air from the west at the angle that produces this effect. The face has always formed at dusk. Whoever carved the mechanism chose that face because it matches what the mountain shows at sunset, not as a mystery to

solve, but as an acknowledgment: *I know the same thing you know.* Whatever made both faces was paying attention.

The Northern Rise, the basalt foothills between here and the mountain's base, is visible in the fading light as a dark irregular line below the plume. The bark-map's first landmark begins somewhere out there. The distance, for the first time, feels measurable.

WHAT THE CAVE KNOWS

The cave is old. Its oldest marks predate the current political structure of the Shield Lands, possibly predate the Aerdy presence entirely. The repeated face on the walls, the one that became the mechanism, was made by someone who considered it important, repeated it obsessively, and then left. No remains, no artefacts, no explanation. The face is not Keraptis's work. It is not gnomish. It predates both by centuries and possibly millennia.

The gnomes began using the cave because it was sheltered and because they understand old things without requiring explanations for them. The trappers used it because the gnomes left it safe and they were practical people. The operative used it because the route north required a waystation and this one already existed, which meant no construction, no permanent occupation, no evidence beyond what a careful search would find.

The cave does not care about any of this. It was here before all of them and will be here after. The Ash Tongue face is the oldest thing in the Thicket that is not a tree, and unlike the trees it has not been corrupted by the dust. Whatever made it made it to last.

REFEREE NOTES

ON THE NAME "ASH TONGUE." Old Brindle knows this cave by that name and will explain it if asked: the face is a very old Flan spirit-marker, representing something the Flan called the Voice of the Ash, a forest intelligence that communicated through burned wood and the patterns left by fire on stone. The tongue of the face is carved from ash-grey stone deliberately, not coincidentally. The Flan didn't build the cave, they found it and named what was already there, which is a habit of people who are paying attention. Old Brindle finds the cave's continued existence, uncorrupted, faintly reassuring. He is not a demonstrative man, so this will manifest as a slightly less exhausted expression for the rest of the evening.

ON THE GNOME WARNING. Nib can read it. If she does, she will go quiet for a moment and then say: *"Whoever wrote this*

went in. They came back out. That is more than most.” She does not know who wrote it. She knows the third vent from the east, she has been near enough to the mountain to know the ventilation pattern. She has never gone inside and will not, but she knows this note is accurate. The hammering is something she refuses to explain, and the refusal is not coy. She is genuinely afraid of the answer.

ON THE FRESH OBSIDIAN DISC. It is a key to a specific mechanism inside White Plume Mountain, the one the cracked disc would have opened if used for cave entry had not spent it. It fits a different lock than the face mechanism. A party entering White Plume Mountain with this disc has an advantage a party without it does not: a door that requires no force, no guessing, no spell. The operative’s disc, the one used to bypass this mechanism on entry, is spent. A different disc, Kael Vorst’s or the party’s, if brought here, is keyed to a different door entirely. The door on the other side is at the end of the route on the bark-map. A referee running White Plume Mountain as the sequel should decide what that door opens before the party arrives.

ON THE DUST IN THE CACHE. The two ceramic tubes present the party with one last decision about the substance that has defined this entire adventure. They can destroy it here, carry it out to Elnara, or keep it. The adventure does not make this decision for them. A party that has watched Dort carve K-marks into stone, watched Pirrel lose herself, watched the owlbear, a creature that did nothing wrong except find a crate, tear through three counties in a state of contaminated ecstasy, may find the choice easy. Or they may not. That’s the question the adventure has been asking since the session zero crash.

ON THE CONCLUSION AVAILABLE HERE. The Riddle Cave is the adventure’s furthest point of travel and its deepest information deposit. A party that completes all seven areas has:

- Recovered two of the three legendary weapons
- Identified the smuggling network’s key personnel
- Discovered that the owlbear was deliberately created as a weapon and its territory deliberately prepared
- Established that someone above Sorel Vane is cleaning house and moving north
- Learned a specific route into White Plume Mountain and specific navigation intelligence for its interior

This is not the end of the story. The cave, the bark-map, the gnome’s note, and the fresh obsidian disc make that clear. But this adventure ends here, at the mouth of something larger, with the party possessing more than they expected to find when Elnara said *I need it stopped, the beast, the pool, the cache, whatever is feeding this*. They stopped those things. They have also learned that someone built them, and that person is still building.

The plume above the mountain is visible from the cave mouth if the party looks north. At dusk, the face forms in the smoke. It does not look surprised to be found.

ON VAREK SORN. The full encounter entry is in the Varek Sorn section above. The key referee note: she chose to wait at this cave rather than continue north, which is the single most important fact about her. A person who could leave and chose not to is making a statement. She wants to know who has been following the weapons through the forest. The party should feel, when they find her, that they have been expected.

Her allegiance is not established in this adventure and should not be resolved here. The available evidence supports at least three interpretations, and she will not narrow it. Let the party argue about her on the road north.

The canonical reading of this adventure is that Varek Sorn is Sarra: the woman named in the history document, Laski’s younger sister, the factor from Critwall who lost the person she steered by to the thing in the dark water and then spent fifty years finishing what they would have done. The three aliases, the Critwall origin, the scope of what she has moved toward this mountain, the way she reacts to the Revocation, and the “someone I knew” admission all point the same direction. The module text keeps it ambiguous to give referees room, but the intention is that she is Sarra, and the history document was written to receive that confirmation when a referee is ready to give it.

The Laski thread is not resolved in this adventure. It should not be. The party plants the seed at Area 7. The history document waters it. The confirmation belongs in SF2, underground, when the party meets her again and she finally says the name aloud. That is the scene this adventure is building toward.

CONCLUDING THE ADVENTURE

The adventure ends when the party returns to Ringstown, whether the owlbear is dead or calmed, the dust destroyed or secured, and regardless of how many of the seven areas they explored. Elnara pays the commission without ceremony and asks four questions in sequence, in this order, before saying anything else: *“Is the beast dealt with? Is the pool closed? What did you bring back? And the dust, what you found, what’s left of it. What did you do?”* The fourth question is the one that costs her something to ask.

RETURNING TO ELNARA

Elnara's reactions to what the party returns with:

THE OWLBEAR KILLED: She nods. Writes something in her ledger. Pays 100 gp without comment. If the party asks whether she feels anything about it, she says: *"I feel that the north gate post is not going to crack further. That is enough."*

THE OWLBEAR CALMED (ALTERNATE RESOLUTION): Elnara is quiet for longer than usual. She asks, once: *"You're certain it won't resume?"* When told Old Brindle is attending to it, she accepts this. She pays the full commission and adds 15 gp without explanation. She will send a druidic contact north within the week to assess whether recovery is possible. She does not ask who had that idea.

THE DUST DESTROYED: She adds 20 gp to whatever she owes. She does not call this a bonus. She calls it *"the correct outcome."*

THE DUST CACHE SURRENDERED TO ELNARA: She confiscates it as evidence, pays nothing additional for it, and will not discuss what she intends to do with it. A party that negotiates *before* handing it over can extract an additional 10-25 gp depending on how many doses are present and how well they argue.

THE DUST CACHE KEPT OR SOLD: She does not know. If she finds out later, she will remember.

THE REVOCATION RETURNED: She takes the lead-lined case with both hands. She does not open it. She holds it still for a moment, longer than she holds anything, and then sets it on her desk. She looks at the party. *"This is what all of it was for. The dust, the beast, the network in the Thicket. He was not testing a weapon. He was looking for this."* She adds 50 gp to the commission without negotiation. She does not explain what the tablet says. If the party presses her, she says: *"When the time comes to use it, you will understand why I did not tell you tonight. Some knowledge makes people targets."* She does not look away when she says it.

BLINK'S MANIFEST NAMING "E. FORGER" RETURNED TO HER: She takes it, looks at it for one moment, and places it in her ledger without comment. She adds 10 gp to the commission without explanation. If pressed, she says: *"For your discretion."* She does not confirm what the name means.

THE WEAPON-CONVOY MANIFEST RETURNED TO HER: The one with the routing note signed *E*. She takes it. She does not look at it for long. She places it face-down in her ledger. She adds 10 gp to the commission and says nothing further. The party should understand, if they are paying attention, that she already knows exactly what the document says, because she wrote part of it. If pressed directly, *"Was this your operation?"*, she says: *"Those were my people. The owlbear was not part of my plan. The plan failed."* A pause. *"What matters is what comes after."* She does not look away. This is the closest the adventure comes to

Elnara being accountable for the situation. She authorized a trap that failed catastrophically. She has not stopped trying to salvage it.

WHELM AND/OR BLACKRAZOR RETURNED: She receives each weapon with the same flat expression, relief, carefully managed. She places them in the iron chest with Wave and locks it. She tells the party: *"These three objects are the reason this entire situation exists. Someone underground wants them back. As long as they are here, that someone has a reason to keep looking north."* She does not explain further. She is already thinking about what comes next.

IF THE PARTY DESCRIBES THE FULL PICTURE, THE OPERATIVE, THE MOUNTAIN ROUTE, THE TEST-SITE PATTERN: Elnara is quiet for longer than is comfortable. Then: *"The Thicket wasn't a destination. It was a proving ground. Someone poisoned a forest and a water table and a large animal at range, to see if the dust could do it. It could."* She does not raise her voice. *"I cannot move armed forces into the mountain territory. The district command makes any official action slow and visible, which is worse than nothing."* She looks at the party. *"What I can do is pay, significantly, to the people who already know the enemy's mark, have held the weapons he wants back, and are standing in my office with a map that opens a specific door. If you're willing to be those people."*

She names a figure. The referee should set it high enough to mean something. She does not negotiate it down.

THE CODED LEDGER (AREA 2) AND/OR Kael VORST'S IDENTITY: If the party has connected Kael Vorst to the Inheritor's network and can describe the chain, Inheritor -> Kael -> Sorel -> Mave/Dort -> road, Elnara listens without interrupting. She adds 50 gp (the promised intelligence bonus) and says: *"That confirms what I suspected about the structure. It does not tell me who is at the top of it."* She means this literally.

THE OBSIDIAN DISC (CRACKED, IF THE PARTY USED IT AT AREA 5) FROM AREA 3: She examines it carefully, sets it down. *"Kael Vorst's. He was carrying a live one when we last tracked him, three months ago. This one is spent."* This is the first confirmation that Elnara has been monitoring the Inheritor's network for longer than this adventure suggests. If the party never used the disc at Area 5, it is intact and warm; she will not touch it, will ask the party to set it on the table, and her reaction shifts to the fresh disc entry below.

THE FRESH OBSIDIAN DISC FROM AREA 7: She does not touch it. She asks the party to set it on the table. She looks at it from a distance. *"That came from the cache in the cave."* She does not ask how they know about the cave. She adds 25 gp and says: *"Do not use it. Do not let anyone else use it. I will arrange for it to be examined by someone who can tell me what door it opens."*

THE BARK-MAP FROM AREA 7: She spreads it on her desk and studies it for a full minute. She does not share what she sees

in it. Then she produces her own field notebook and, without being asked, copies out the key landmarks in her precise handwriting, the forks, the iron-red spring, the entry vent. When she is done she slides the bark-map back across the desk to the party. *"You'll need this more than I will. I know the mountain."* She does not explain what she means by that. The party has the original.

THE GNOME WARNING (GNOMISH, FROM AREA 7): If the party cannot read it, she can. She reads it twice. Her expression does not change. She says: *"The third vent from the east."* Then: *"Someone has been inside and come back. Recently."* She looks at the party. *"That is more than I knew this morning."*

WHAT REMAINS OPEN

The adventure resolves its immediate threats but does not close the larger story. These threads remain when the party leaves Ringstown:

IF THE CLEANSING RITE WAS NEVER PERFORMED: The pool at Area 4 remains active (if the party never reached it) or remains unaddressed. The owlbear, if killed, died at the height of its contamination rather than at partial suppression, it fought harder and the party paid for it. Elnara pays the commission without comment. Old Brindle, if he learns the rite was never completed, says only: *"The pool will need closing. Someone will have to go back."* He does not say it accusingly. He says it because it is true.

THE INHERITOR IS STILL ACTIVE. The false Keraptis was watching through the pool, through the K-marks, through the owlbear's borrowed eyes. The pool is closed. The owlbear is dealt with. The control apparatus in the Thicket is dismantled. But the source, the laboratory under the mountain, the manufactured dust, the copies of Keraptis fighting over a dead wizard's identity, is untouched. White Plume Mountain still smokes. The face still forms at dusk.

THE SILK-WEARING OPERATIVE IS IN THE RIDDLE CAVE. They killed Kael Vorst and Orn, solved the puzzle at Area 7, and chose to wait rather than continue north. The party encountered them. What came of that encounter shapes what comes next: if a deal was made, the operative knows exactly what the party found and what they intend, and they have gone north carrying the same information. If combat or flight, the operative knows less but is still moving. If the encounter resolved in conversation, the party is carrying north the knowledge that someone else has been building toward this for thirty years. What the operative knows about the party's discoveries, the cracked disc, the broken pool, the calmed owlbear, depends on whether the detection mechanism in the cache was triggered and whether the pool at Area 4 was still

active when it fired. If the pool was closed, the signal reached no one. If the pool was active, the false Keraptis was watching.

THE WEAPONS REMEMBER THE MOUNTAIN. A character who has carried Whelm since Area 2 may notice, on the approach to the Riddle Cave or afterward, a faint rhythmic vibration in the haft, something between a pulse and a lean, growing slightly stronger when they face northeast. Whelm was forged in the mountain. It has not stopped knowing which direction home is. A dwarf carrier feels this more acutely: the hammer does not fight to move, but it inclines, the way a compass needle inclines, toward the northeast, without urgency and without rest.

Blackrazor does not orient toward a direction. It orients toward depth, toward mass, toward presence, toward the weight of something very large underground that has been waiting long enough to stop feeling like waiting. When the party is north of Ringstown, in the foothills, this becomes a pressure rather than a pull. The mountain is full of old things. One of them is waiting. Blackrazor can feel it, and anyone carrying Blackrazor will eventually feel Blackrazor feel it.

Wave does neither of these things. Wave is a sea weapon, aquatic in origin, aligned with open water rather than underground fire and sulphur, and the mountain is essentially everything it is not: enclosed, volcanic, dark, dry. If Whelm leans northeast and Blackrazor pulls toward depth, Wave leans south, toward the coast, toward whatever open water it considers home. A character carrying Wave into the mountain foothills may feel a faint resistance, the way a tool feels wrong in the hand when used for a purpose it was not made for. Wave will function. It will not cooperate. The party is taking it somewhere it does not want to go, and it will be quietly, persistently clear about this for as long as they are heading inland.

THE PARTY HAS BEEN SEEN. If any character held the pool's attention during the cleansing rite, they made eye contact with the false Keraptis, and he saw them clearly. That night in Ringstown, that character dreams: a vast underground space, stone vaulting in firelight, and something enormous beginning to turn toward them. They wake before it finishes turning. But the attention remains, the particular weight of having been studied by an intelligence that does not sleep, does not rest, has been watching through every contaminated pool and marked tree and borrowed animal for months. They now know that face. It now knows theirs. Whether the party chooses to go north is entirely their decision. But one of them will always know they have been seen, and the thing that saw them is still down there.

SOREL VANE IS ALIVE (IF THE PARTY ALLOWED IT). He has a family in Critwall, a contact address hidden in his boot lining, and detailed knowledge of the Inheritor's buyer

network. He is not a villain. He is a man who took a bad contract and wants to survive it. Whether the party honoured the safe-passage agreement determines whether he is a future resource or a future complication.

OLD BRINDLE IS IN THE THICKET (if he survived and the party left him at the hollow or the glade). He will not return to Ringstown until the owlbear situation is fully resolved in his judgment, which may take weeks. Yenna knows something is still wrong. She will ask the party whether they saw him. She will ask once, quietly, and accept whatever they tell her without arguing.

THE THREE WEAPONS ARE IN ELNARA'S POSSESSION. All three together, in a locked chest, in a fortified gatehouse on the edge of a town that the false Keraptis has been watching through a contaminated groundwater spring. Elnara is not unaware of this irony.

OUTCOME VARIATIONS

IF THE DUST WAS DESTROYED IN ITS ENTIRETY: The contamination in the immediate area begins to recede within days. Animals return to the game trails within a week. Old Brindle, when he eventually emerges, will say the forest is recovering, slowly, with the particular stubbornness of things that have been sick for a long time. The underlying source in the mountain is unchanged, but the Thicket's infection is clearing.

IF THE DUST WAS PRESERVED OR SOLD: The substance continues to exist in the world. Whoever holds it, Elnara, a Critwall buyer, the party, holds a temptation and a liability. The Inheritor will want it back or want to know who took it. Kelpwick, if he purchased doses from the party, will have questions about their provenance that he does not ask aloud for at least a week.

IF PARTY MEMBERS USED THE DUST REPEATEDLY: End with a quiet moment: a character notices they have scratched something into a surface without intending to. They look at what they carved. It is a K. They do not remember doing it. The voice, if there was ever a voice, is not there anymore. But the habit is.

IF THE PARTY EXPLORED ALL SEVEN AREAS: They leave Ringstown with the bark-map (if Elnara didn't take it), the gnome's navigation note, a fresh obsidian disc that opens a door somewhere underground, and the knowledge that the previous expedition that retrieved these three weapons did not make it home. They have a route. They have intelligence no one else has. They have weapons of legendary provenance. White Plume Mountain is north, and now they know how to go in rather than merely where.

THE COMMISSION

This ask is not conditional on the party having assembled the full picture. Elnara commissions any party that returned with the weapons and demonstrated competence in the Thicket. She may explain more or less depending on what they brought back, but she always asks.

She waits until the accounting is done. Then:

She does not say *the mountain is dangerous* or *this will be difficult*. She says: *"The source is still there. The network in the Thicket was a test, not a destination. Something underground has been moving weapons toward a mountain for years, and I cannot move forces there officially without district authorization that would take months and arrive too visibly to do any good."*

She looks at the party. *"What I can do is pay people who already know the enemy's mark, have held the weapons, and are standing in my office with a route. If you are willing to be those people."*

She names a figure. Set it high enough to matter. She does not negotiate it down.

ON THE WEAPONS: She does not tell the party to bring the weapons to the mountain. She does not tell them not to. If asked directly: *"The weapons are yours to decide. I am not certain they are safer here than north of here. What I am certain of is that the mountain is the source and someone needs to go to the source."* She will not be drawn further on this. The decision is the party's.

REFEREE NOTE: This is the moment SF1 ends and the campaign toward White Plume Mountain begins. If the party is hesitant, the weapons themselves may settle the question: Whelm has been leaning northeast since Area 2. Blackrazor has been pulling toward depth. The route north will feel, to any character who has been carrying either weapon, less like a choice than a direction they have been facing since the Thicket.

THE FINAL IMAGE

Read this when the party departs Ringstown heading north, or as the closing image of this session.

Elnara holds the commission for a moment before setting it on the desk. She looks at the party, then at the map, then north, in the way she has been looking north all season.

"The Thicket is contained. That buys time, not safety. The source is still there." A pause. "You have the cave map. You have the disc. You have held the weapons he wants back." She does not raise her voice. "I cannot move forces north without authorisation that would take longer than we have. But I can pay, significantly, people who are already standing in my office with the right intelligence and no official attachment." She names a figure. She does not negotiate it down.

She does not say be careful or good luck. She unlocks the iron chest, checks that all three weapons are accounted for, and locks it again.

The pool is dark. The hollow is quiet. At dusk, looking north from the south gate, the plume above the mountain catches the last light and holds a face for three or four seconds, the same face that was carved into the cave wall before anyone alive was born, and then the light shifts and it is only smoke again.

The cave map in your pack shows the first landmark north of the treeline. The distance, for the first time, feels measurable.

FOREST TIE-INS

The Twisted Thicket should feel like the infected outer skin of White Plume Mountain rather than an isolated woodland. The following elements connect this adventure to the larger world and to any sequel.

THE GNOME BERRY-GATHERERS. Mountain gnomes have worked these trails for generations. They know vents, routes, and the mountain's internal rhythm in ways no surface expedition can match. Nib (Area 6), if the party treated her well, is a potential contact for a future expedition, she will not go inside, but she knows who among the mountain gnomes might. Their knotted trail cords and chalked directional arrows are a living warning system; as long as the gnomes are still marking trails, the situation above ground has not become completely hopeless.

DEAD GNOLL'S EYE SOCKET. A blasted hollow roughly two hours northeast of the Riddle Cave, named for its shape. Former gnoll territory, long since abandoned. The gnomes use it as a waystation on the approach to the mountain's outer vents. It functions as a fallback camp, a hidden cache point, or a place where a party waiting for the mountain smoke to turn grey can shelter without being exposed on the approach. It is not in any area of this adventure; it appears on no map the party has found. Old Brindle knows it exists. Nib can describe its location. A referee running a sequel into White Plume

Mountain should populate it with whatever serves the next chapter.

THE PLUME AS OMEN. At dusk, looking north from anywhere in the Thicket with a clear sightline, the glade, the game trails, the cave mouth, the smoke above White Plume Mountain briefly forms a face. It does not move. It does not react to being observed. It simply watches, the way an intelligence watches when it believes it cannot be seen watching. After this adventure, the party has seen the pool behind that face, heard the pool's voice described by Old Brindle, and possibly made eye contact with it directly. The face at dusk is no longer an abstract omen. It is a person they have almost met, looking south from a place they now know how to reach.

RUMOUR TABLE

Roll 1d100. Rumours may be heard in Ringstown taverns, at the market, from travellers, or from NPCs with relevant knowledge. The referee should use rumours appropriate to the source, a trapper knows the Thicket, a guardsman knows the garrison's mood, a merchant knows trade patterns.

TRUTH KEY: T = True. F = False. ~ = Partially true or misleading.

REFeree NOTE ON RUMOUR #99: There is no human spy in Ringstown. The truth behind this rumour is the scrying connection, the false Keraptis has been observing through the contaminated pool and dust traces in the area, not through a human informant. Players who investigate will find no agent. If pressed, the source of the rumour is likely Brother Aldric's documented case notes being read by the wrong person, or simply the paranoia that accumulates in a town that has watched three carriages not come back. The ~ rating reflects that *someone* is watching, but not in the way the rumour describes.

D%	RUMOUR	
01	"That owlbear glows. Not like foxfire, like something is burning inside it. Three separate survivors said the same thing before they stopped talking about it."	T

02	"The powder they found at the wreck sites tastes sweet. That's how you know it's dangerous. Nothing that sweet out here is natural."	~
03	"Blink Tinderflip hasn't been seen in Critwall since he handed off those crates. Word is he left owing money to a lot of people."	~
04	"Elnara's been sending ravens south for two weeks. None of them are coming back with answers."	T
05	"The mountain's been smoking heavier than usual. Old Posk says that happened once before, forty years ago, and that was a bad winter for everyone."	~
06	"There's a gnome out past the tree line who trades plumeberries for coin. Friendly enough. Keeps asking whether you've found any interesting powder on the road."	~
07	"White Plume Mountain was named for a wizard who burned to death on its slopes. The smoke is his ghost. You don't go there."	F
08	"That powder makes you feel like a god for about ten minutes, then you start scratching letters into things. My cousin did it on a dare. He's fine. Mostly."	T
09	"They found a dead smuggler two miles out with all his coin still on him. Whatever killed him wasn't after money."	T

10	"Keraptis died a hundred years ago. Anyone telling you otherwise wants something from you."	~
11	"Those crates Tinderflip was moving were packed in bladder-skin lining. You do that for things that can't get wet, or things that can't be smelled."	T
12	"Old Brindle can call the owlbear off. He just won't do it for free."	F
13	"The paths in the Thicket change. You walk in on a straight road and come out somewhere else. The trees move when no one's watching."	F
14	"There's a cave in the Thicket with old writing carved inside. Some of the trappers used to use it as a waystation before all this started."	T
15	"The beast screams words. Not animal sounds, words. Rennick heard it say a name before it took his arm."	~
16	"River water cures the dust sickness. Just drink a lot of it and the voice goes away."	F
17	"Sorel Vane was in the Scalded Goblin three nights ago. Quiet. Drinking alone. Watching the door."	~
18	"Elnara already has one of the old weapons. She's had it for some time. That's why she wants the others so badly."	~

19	"The gnomes under the mountain serve Keraptis willingly. Always have. They think he's a god."	~
20	"There's a pool deep in the Thicket that glows white-blue. Locals say it cleans the dust out of you if you wash in it."	~
21	"That owlbear was seen by Renwick's boys in early spring, normal as anything. Whatever happened to it happened fast and recently."	T
22	"You can burn the dust out of a wound with a torch. It hurts, but the voice stops."	F
23	"The smugglers were taking orders from someone connected to the mountain. Sorel Vane let that slip after his third drink."	T
24	"There's a goblin warband working out of a den north of the Thicket. The owlbear problem is just cover for a raid they're planning."	F
25	"Blink Tinderflip is a gnome. Small, fast-talking, never stays in one place long enough to be accountable. Classic."	T
26	"A face forms in the smoke above the mountain at dusk. Perfectly clear. It's been happening every night for a month."	T
27	"The logging camp foreman made it back to Ringstown. He's not talking, but he's here."	T

28	"The dust makes animals aggressive. Not just the owlbear, weasels, deer, things that have no reason to attack a man."	T
29	"There are K-marks scratched into trees throughout the Thicket. Some old, some fresh. Nobody knows what they mean."	T
30	"Thingizzard's shop in Ringstown isn't actually hers. Someone's just using her name because people are afraid of it."	~
31	"The three weapons Tinderflip was moving were taken from White Plume Mountain by a previous expedition. Elnara hired that group too."	~
32	"Kelpwick the gnome is Thingizzard in disguise. The hair is wrong and she doesn't smell right."	F
33	"One of those three weapons won't cooperate with the wrong hands. A man in Critwall tried to use it and couldn't hit a target at ten feet. Gave it back and wouldn't say why."	T
34	"Durven Ash has the best metalwork in Ringstown but he won't admit the Kolm woman exists. Bessa thinks it's hilarious."	T
35	"Old Brindle hasn't come to market in three weeks. His niece is pretending not to be worried."	T

36	"Blackrazor drains the life out of whatever it kills. The wielder feels it happen. Some people like that."	~
37	"The Shield Post has a locked room in the basement full of confiscated goods from the last ten years. Coss won't say what's in it."	F
38	"Wave calls to water. If you hold it near a river, the river leans toward it."	T
39	"The owlbear has been seen as far south as the main Critwall road. It's expanding its range."	F
40	"Brod Chandler has crates in his warehouse he won't let anyone near. They've been sitting there three weeks and nobody's collected them."	T
41	"The powder was made underground, in a laboratory. It's not harvested, it's manufactured."	T
42	"You can tell who's used the dust because their eyes go white around the iris. Temporary, but it lasts a day or so."	F
43	"Elnara was a Shield Lands intelligence officer before she took the ranger post. She knows more about White Plume Mountain than she admits."	~
44	"There's more than one Keraptis. The original is gone but the copies are fighting each other for control of the mountain."	T

45	"The cave with the old writing is a trap. The riddle is designed to lure people into a deadfall."	F
46	"The gnome berry-gatherers leave warning markers for each other in the trees. Knotted cords, coloured stones. A whole language."	T
47	"The dust doesn't affect gnomes. Their blood chemistry is different. Something about the stone they grew up in."	F
48	"Sorel Vane will sell out his employers for the right price. He's loyal to coin, not causes."	T
49	"A face appeared in the mountain smoke and stayed there for a full minute. Didn't move. Just watched."	~
50	"The logging camp attack happened mid-afternoon. Not at night. The beast doesn't care what time it is."	T
51	"White Plume Mountain erupts on a cycle. The last eruption was eighty years ago. We're due."	F
52	"Kelpwick has something in his shop that counteracts the dust's worst effects. He's not advertising it."	T
53	"The Bootless King in Ring Square was a Flan warlord who held this ground against the Aerdy for three seasons. Someone stole the top half of the statue."	~

54	"The town well tastes different than it did a month ago. Faintly of minerals. Like licking a coin."	T
55	"There were three legendary weapons taken from White Plume Mountain by a group of adventurers. Keraptis has been trying to get them back ever since."	T
56	"The voice you hear after the dust wears off isn't in your head. Something is actually speaking. It's just very far away."	~
57	"The glade north of the logging camp smells wrong. Sweet and cold at the same time. Animals won't go near it."	T
58	"There are bones north of the logging camp. A lot of them. Something has been using that area as a feeding ground."	T
59	"You can track the owlbear by the white powder prints it leaves when it's in frenzy. Glows faintly in the dark."	~
60	"The owlbear has young somewhere in the Thicket. That's why it's so aggressive, it's protecting a nest."	F
61	"Elnara is paying a hundred gold pieces for proof the owlbear is dead. She'll add fifty if you bring back anything connected to the powder."	~
62	"The smugglers had a second wagon that got through before the owlbear went mad. Whoever was expecting that shipment is still expecting it."	F

63	"Old Brindle tried to cleanse that glowing pool in the Thicket. Whatever is in it drove him back. He doesn't talk about it."	T
64	"White Plume Mountain has been explored before, many times. The ones who come back mostly come back changed."	T
65	"Keraptis achieved immortality by copying his mind into a spell. The copies think they're the real one. They're all wrong."	T
66	"Wave doesn't like being away from water. It sulks. You can feel it in the grip."	~
67	"Blink Tinderflip owes Fennick Oyle three months of market fees. Fennick will share this with anyone who asks."	~
68	"The north gate hasn't been fully opened in a month. Elnara's orders. Whatever comes through from the Thicket, she wants it to come through one at a time."	T
69	"There was a fourth carriage that disappeared entirely before the first bodies were found. Elnara denies this."	F
70	"The gnomes inside the mountain aren't all loyal to Keraptis. Some of them are trying to get out."	T
71	"Yenna Brindle's uncle is dead. She just hasn't accepted it yet."	F

72	"The K-marks in the Thicket are a summoning alphabet. If you arrange the right ones in sequence, something answers."	F
73	"A previous expedition actually recovered all three weapons and made it out of the mountain. They just didn't make it home."	~
74	"You can buy the dust in Critwall if you know the right people. It's called plume's kiss in the trade."	~
75	"Whelm was made by dwarves. Not for humans. It doesn't like being held by anything without stone in its blood."	~
76	"That shimmering in the dust isn't gemstone powder. It's residual magic. The stuff is basically a failed spell in solid form."	T
77	"The owlbear will calm down at dawn when the dust cycle breaks. You just have to survive the night."	F
78	"There are survivors from the logging camp attack who could guide you there. They won't. You'd have to drag them."	~
79	"The Twisted Thicket was ordinary forest fifty years ago. Hunters worked it every season. Something changed."	T

80	"The Shield Lands government knows about the weapons and has quietly authorised Elnara to secure them. She's acting with backing she doesn't advertise."	T
81	"The obsidian token from the cave in the Thicket is a passage marker. Show it at the right place and something opens."	~
82	"Sorel Vane is working for Elnara. The whole smuggling operation was a sting. The owlbear wasn't part of the plan."	F
83	"The dust leaves traces in water. If you drop a pinch in a cup, the water goes white-blue for an hour."	T
84	"Whoever controls the dust controls the mountain. That's what the false Keraptis believes, anyway."	~
85	"The Thicket has always had a bad reputation. Before the dust, before the beast. There are things in there that predate the town."	~
86	"Blackrazor sings. Not out loud, in your chest. You feel it before you hear it. The feeling is not unpleasant, which is the problem."	~
87	"Whelm calls back to its maker. If you hold it in the dark and listen, you hear hammering."	~

88	"The logging camp survivors all drew the same symbol without talking to each other. Nobody told them to. They didn't know they were doing it."	T
89	"The north road goes all the way to the mountain if you follow it. Nobody does."	T
90	"The dust only affects the weak-minded. Strong-willed people can shake it off. The voice is just a test."	F
91	"Brother Aldric has been keeping records of every dust-related symptom he's seen. He has seventeen cases documented. He thinks it's spreading."	T
92	"If you destroy the glowing pool in the Thicket, the owlbear dies. The pool is its heart."	F
93	"Senna the herbalist has samples of contaminated plant matter from the Thicket edge. She'll show you if you ask."	T
94	"The owlbear attacked its own territory. Owlbears don't do that. Whatever is in the dust rewrote its instincts."	T
95	"Keraptis is watching through the dust. Through the marks. Through the smoke above the mountain. He's been watching for a while."	~
96	"There's a dragon sleeping under White Plume Mountain. Keraptis was just the tenant."	F

97	"The weapons want to go back to the mountain. They were made there. If you carry them long enough, you'll start walking north without knowing why."	F
98	"The powder was designed to make soldiers. Controllable, powerful, loyal to the voice. The owlbear is what happens when the dose isn't calibrated."	~
99	"Someone in Ringstown is sending reports on the party's movements to a contact in the north. Has been since the carriages arrived."	~
100	"Keraptis isn't gone. Keraptis was never one person. Keraptis is an idea, and ideas don't die. They just wait for the right mind to move into."	T

APPENDIX: THE THREE WEAPONS

Referee reference only. Do not distribute to players. Full treatment in S2 White Plume Mountain.

WAVE

TRIDENT +3 (1d6+3 / 1d6+3) | Alignment: Neutral | Int 14, Ego 10

Communication: Empathy.

PROPERTIES:

- Wielder breathes water as air.
- Wielder communicates with aquatic creatures (telepathy, 30 ft.).
- Detect evil/good at will (60 ft., silent).
- *Create water* 3x/day (as spell).
- *Purify food and drink* 3x/day (as spell).
- *Part water* 1x/day (as spell).
- Summon water elemental 1x/week (16 HD; serves 1 turn, then departs).

Personality: Wave yearns toward the sea and resists movement northeast toward the mountain. A wielder attempting to carry it toward White Plume Mountain must succeed on a Wisdom check each day or find their steps turning south. It does not hate its wielder; it simply has somewhere else it wants to be.

WHELM

WARHAMMER +3 (1d4+3+3 vs. S/M, 1d4+2+3 vs. L) | Alignment: Lawful Neutral | Int 15, Ego 10

Communication: Speech (Common, Dwarvish).

PROPERTIES:

- Can be thrown up to 60 ft.; returns to hand at the start of the wielder's next round.
- Detect gold and gems within 60 ft. (continuous, silent).
- Detect goblinoids within 60 ft. (continuous, silent).
- *Locate object* 2x/day (as spell, 120 ft.).
- Giants struck must save vs. spells or be panicked for 1d4 rounds (flee at full speed).
- DWARVES: +4 total (not +3); immune to Whelm's fear effect; Whelm communicates freely and willingly.

Personality: Whelm pulls northeast. Dwarves carrying it report it as a tug, a direction with urgency behind it. Non-dwarves describe it as a restlessness or a feeling of unfinished business. It is patient but persistent. It wants to go to the mountain.

BLACKRAZOR

GREATSWORD +3 (1d10+3 vs. S/M, 3d6+3 vs. L) | Alignment: Chaotic Neutral | Int 16, Ego 19

Communication: Speech (Common, Elvish, Orcish).

PROPERTIES:

- Sense life within 60 ft. (continuous; wielder always knows when living creatures are nearby).
- *Haste* (self only) 3x/day (as spell, 10 rounds).
- SOUL DRINKING: When Blackrazor kills a creature of 2+ HD or levels, it absorbs the soul. The wielder immediately gains temporary HP equal to the slain creature's maximum HP (duration 1 hour; stacks, excess lost). For the same duration, the wielder gains +2 STR (maximum 20).
- If the wielder drops below half maximum HP, Blackrazor urges attack against the nearest living creature, friend or foe. Resisting requires a successful Wisdom check.
- OPPOSED TO WAVE: If Wave is within 60 ft., Blackrazor's bonus drops to +1 and its soul-drinking is suppressed.

Personality: Blackrazor has the highest ego of the three weapons and is the most dangerous to wield. It does not care about its wielder's goals; it cares about its wielder being alive and killing things. It will work with whoever holds it, as long as they keep feeding it. It hungers toward depth and underground, away from water, away from the sea. It ended up in the Thicket because the Inheritor's network was routing it toward the mountain, and the mountain goes down.

All three weapons resist being brought together at White Plume Mountain. This resistance is not a trap or a puzzle. It is a warning.

MAP OF RINGTOWN (TACTICAL)



Referee use. Shows all named buildings and key locations within Ringtown.

The Twisted Thicket

MODULE SF1 • LEVELS 5-7 • 4-6 PLAYERS

OSRIC / AD&D 2E COMPATIBLE



North of the settled roadlands, agents of an ancient evil have been smuggling a refined magical stimulant through the Twisted Thicket. When a cargo wagon overturned in a ravine, an adult owlbear devoured the contents and was transformed. It now tears through the forest in bouts of ecstatic fury, trailing cold white sparks, while those who sample the dust experience terrible strength, obsession, and flashes of a hostile and alien intelligence.

The characters are hired to enter the Thicket, stop the killings, and recover or destroy any contraband. Their investigation leads through seven connected locations: a wrecked smuggler's wagon, a damaged logging camp, a corrupted woodland pool, a thorn-choked hollow, and finally a cave that opens onto something much larger than a single forest.

This module is designed as a compact single-session outdoor adventure and as a prologue to White Plume Mountain. It includes a complete wandering encounter table and full sequel hooks.

For use with the OSRIC rules system and AD&D 2nd Edition

Suitable for 4-6 players • Characters of levels 5-7